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Elevator, Where Elevated Talks Are Left Behind

The real thoughts after any office meeting are aired in the other closed-door consultation that's going up or down SUNDAY CHATTER ▸▸ 6

magazine

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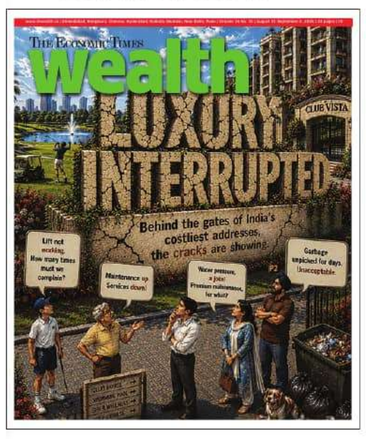
Pure Politics & Bottom Line

ET WEALTH ON MONDAY



PUREPOLITICS

PAGE ▸▸ 2

Plans Afoot for Modi & Xi Meet at SCO, to Set Stage for India Visit

PM Narendra Modi is expected to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping in Bishkek on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit early next week ahead of Xi's India trip for the BRICS Summit here on September 12-13 to help rebuild economic partnership. **Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury** reports.

Nepal Floods Toll at 669; India Speeds Up Warning System for 188 Lakes

The Centre is stepping up efforts to set up early warning systems (EWS) across 188 critical lakes in the Indian Himalayan Region (IHR) that are vulnerable to glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs) as the death toll in the devastating Rasuwa-Bhote Koshi flash floods has risen to 669 as of 4 pm on Saturday.

'NOT MERELY A MARKET TO SERVE'

FM Urges Global Cos to Build for World from India

Next opportunity is to build higher-value businesses in AI, product development, engineering, analytics, semiconductors and electronics, with India's GCCs increasingly becoming global innovation hubs

Opportunity to harness India's talent, mfg scale and tech ecosystem, says Sitharaman

Press Trust of India

Washington: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman invited global investors to set up manufacturing bases, and technology and innovation centres in India, urging them to leverage talent and opportunity to build for the world.

Addressing a high-level Business Roundtable with leading investors and business leaders in Chicago on Friday, Sitharaman highlighted India's broad-based growth, reform momentum and expanding opportunities for long-term investment.

Sitharaman emphasised that India's investment proposition rests not on any single sector, but on the convergence of scale, growth, talent, infrastructure, technology and sustained reform over the past decade.

"The policy environment is increasingly focused on enabling businesses to invest, manufacture, innovate and expand," she said at the roundtable organised by India's Consulate General in Chicago in association with US-India Strategic Partnership Forum.

The FM invited global partners to co-develop, co-produce and build for global markets.

She urged them not to consider India merely as a market to serve, but as a platform from which to build for the world — whether as a manufacturing base, technology and innovation centre, consumer market or destination for long-term infrastructure investment — leveraging India's engineering talent, manufacturing scale and technology ecosystem.

The focus of the meeting was "Manufacture in India-for India and for the world", with opportunities across manufacturing, AI & digital, financial services, infrastructure, food processing, defence and advanced technologies. "As global companies reassess supply chains and capital allocation, India offers not only scale as a market, but increasing depth as a long-term investment and operating platform," Sitharaman said.

Digital Public Infra ▸▸ 7

REFORMS LIKELY TO BE ON AGENDA

GST Council to Meet on Sept 12

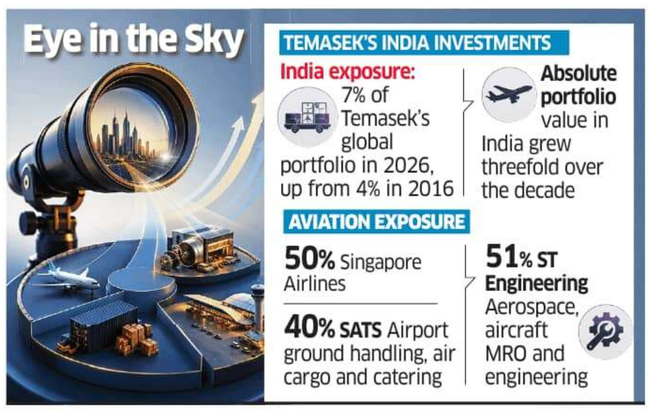
The GST Council is set to meet on September 12 to consider reforms including making it easier to get blocked input tax credit, simplifying the GST treatment of corporate guarantees and allowing small businesses to register in multiple states. **Anuradha Shukla** reports. ▸▸ 3

FRESH FUNDING APPEAL UNDER SCRUTINY

Temasek Backs SIA to Fly Long Haul with Air India

Singapore investor bullish on partnership despite loss-making Indian carrier's woes

Forum Gandhi



Mumbai: Singapore state investor Temasek has backed Singapore Airlines' investment in Air India, as a fresh funding request from the latter draws scrutiny in Singapore over the airline's growing exposure to the loss-making Indian carrier.

Temasek, which owns about 50.41% of Singapore Airlines (SIA), said it supports the carrier's long-term strategy despite the challenges facing Air India.

"As a shareholder of SIA, Temasek views their business decision from a long-term perspective and is supportive of it," Juliet Teo, joint head of portfolio development and head of ecosystem enablement at Temasek Singapore, said in a statement published on its website on Saturday. Singapore Airlines holds a 25.1% stake in Air India, with Tata Sons owning the rest.

Air India has sought around $1.5 billion in fresh equity from its owners, Reuters reported earlier this week.

The funding request has triggered concerns in Singapore. Kenneth Tiong, a lawmaker from the opposition Workers' Party, has urged the government to ensure that Temasek's funds are not used to shore up the Indian carrier. "No one, least of all Singaporeans, owes Air India a living... If Singapore Airlines wants to continue its bet on Air India, it should do so on its own two feet, and not on Temasek's," Tiong said in a note.

He sought oral answers from Singapore's transport minister Jeffrey Siow during the upcoming parliamentary session on September 8, **ET** reported earlier. Teo, however, said Temasek recognises that the large-scale transformation of Air India involves complex, multi-year operational and integration challenges.

Efforts of this scale take time and "are not expected to be linear, particularly in the aviation sector, where outcomes are shaped by industry developments, including aircraft innovation and fleet renewal cycles, and external factors such as airspace disruptions, geopolitical developments, and fuel price volatility," she explained.

Singapore Airlines could be facing a fresh capital call after reporting its first quarterly loss since 2022. The result came despite record revenue, as weaker performance at Air India and a sharp increase in jet fuel costs weighed on the group. Its investment in Air India has become a growing financial burden for SIA.

Challenges Since 2024 ▸▸ 7

ENDING SPECULATION OVER EXTENSION

HDFC Bank CEO to Step Down in Oct

Jagdishan tells board he won't be seeking reappointment; bank to fast-track selection

Our Bureau

Mumbai: HDFC Bank managing director and chief executive officer Sashidhar Jagdishan on Saturday informed the board that he does not wish to seek reappointment when his term ends in October, ending speculation over whether he would get an extension after a three-decade association with India's largest private-sector lender.

The bank's board, while taking note of Jagdishan's decision, said it would "fast-track the process for selection and appointment of his successor well within time".

Deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha is the bank's senior-most executive and is seen as a leading internal contender to succeed Jagdishan.

The board is required to recommend at least three candidates to the Reserve Bank of India for approval. This could include external candidates.

"Despite persuasion, Jagdishan reiterated his decision not to seek reappointment," the bank said.

The decision follows months of uncertainty over Jagdishan's future at the bank.

Questions over his continuation intensified in March after former chairman Atanu Chakraborty exited the bank, citing governance concerns.

At the time, Jagdishan sought to reassure investors, saying he was willing to continue if the board recommended his name for another term.

An external legal review report submitted at the end of June said it found no evidence supporting the former chairman's resignation concern.

However, a board meeting held in July after the approval of the June-quarter results ended without any announcement on his reappointment, fuelling speculation over his reappointment.

Indications of Shorter Tenure ▸▸ 7

Flashback

- **1996** Jagdishan joins HDFC Bank
- **2020** Takes over from Aditya Puri as MD & CEO
- **Mar 2026:** Chairman Atanu Chakraborty resigns, cites governance concerns
- **April** Jagdishan says will continue if backed by board
- **June** Former finance secy Rajiv Kumar takes charge as HDFC Bank chairman
- **July** Board delays decision on Jagdishan's reappointment after Q1 results
- **July 23, 2026** Board penalises Jagdishan, two execs after MSRDC deposit review
- **Aug 29** He declines reappointment; board fast-tracks CEO succession
- **Oct 26** Set to retire after 30 yrs at bank

EXPORTERS SEEK BAN ON MYANMAR ROUTE

Hairline Fix: India Wants to Snip China's Growth

India ships human hair, conflict-ridden Myanmar processes and China profits

Shantanu Nandan Sharma

New Delhi: China, the world's largest manufacturer of wigs and hair extensions, is allegedly relying more on conflict-hit Myanmar as a base for processing human hair sourced largely from India, according to people aware of the matter. Some of these processing units in Myanmar are allegedly using child labour, they told **ET**.

The growing trade has alarmed Indian wig and hair extension exporters, who are seeking a ban on the Myanmar route.

India exported around $940 million worth of human hair in FY26. About 98% of the exported volume of unprocessed hair, worth about $282 million, went to Myanmar, marking a 43% jump over the previous year.

Two Indian exporters told ET that the actual trade is far larger, with smuggled consignments running into multiples of the official volume, crossing the porous border through barter arrangements.

"China does not want us to acquire the latest technology and emerge as a serious wig-manufacturing hub. Otherwise, why would it deny visas to some 100 Indian hair exporters who wanted to attend the China Hair Expo in Guangzhou from August 1 to 3?" said a Chennai-based exporter, requesting not to be named. "We waited until the last date, only to be told that our visas had been rejected. Some exporters even paid $6,000 each for stall booking."

Domestic Push ▸▸ 7

Fuel & Vehicle Costs Reshape Gig Worker Hiring

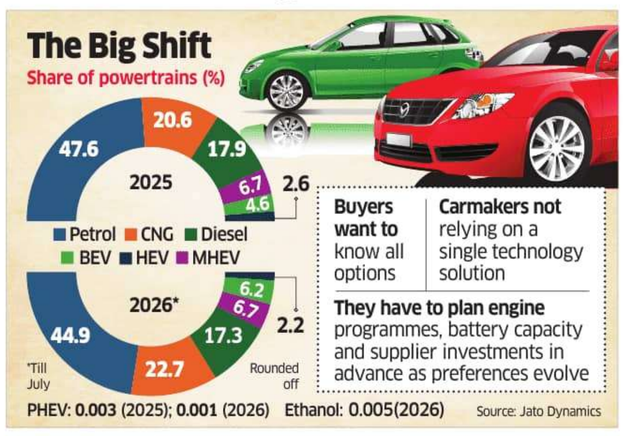
Rising fuel and vehicle operating costs are making gig workers more selective about jobs, with many opting for roles that offer predictable earnings or lower costs. This is prompting firms to expand incentives, EV-linked opportunities and fixed-pay jobs, recruitment experts said. **Neil Ghai** & **Prachi Verma** report. ▸▸ 3

CNG Prices Hiked by ₹3.89 in Delhi amid W Asia Crisis

Indraprastha Gas Ltd has raised the CNG price by ₹3.89 per kg in Delhi and its nearly 20 other licensed areas from Sunday. The move is aimed at offsetting higher gas procurement costs after the Iran war caused global gas benchmarks to double. In Delhi, CNG is being retailed at ₹86.98 per kg. ▸▸ 3

IN A STATE OF FLUX

Auto Cos Open to All Paths as Petrol on Shaky Ground



New launches offer more powertrain options as buyers turn more selective

Lijee Philip

Mumbai: MG just launched an SUV with both plug-in hybrid (PHEV) and electric powertrains, while Skoda is bringing the diesel Superb back to India. Hyundai is expanding its CNG portfolio while preparing new EVs, and Maruti Suzuki continues to back CNG alongside other options.

These launches and upcoming models point to an unusual phase in India's automobile market — petrol's dominance is weakening, but carmakers are widening, not narrowing, their powertrain bets. CNG, diesel, hybrids, EVs and now PHEVs are all competing for space, with the contest moving deeper into mass market.

In the backdrop of transition to ethanol-blended petrol, automakers appear to be hedging their bets rather than committing to a single successor to petrol, making India's shift away from its dominant fuel a complex, and potentially costly, transition, say experts.

"The future of mobility will not be defined by a single technology solution but by providing customers the freedom to choose the pathway that best suits their needs," JSW MG Motor India managing director Anurag Mehrotra said at the recent launch of the MG Hector Tomahawk, which is available in EV and PHEV variants.

What is emerging is not simply a transition from petrol to electric, but "a transition from one dominant powertrain to a much more fragmented market", said Ravi Bhatia, president, Jato Dynamics. In other words, carmakers are buying optionality. "The challenge is that optionality is expensive; you have to invest today for several possible versions of tomorrow," he said.

Product Planning ▸▸ 7

VCs Follow Online Creators Jumping on the Brandwagon

With huge social media fan base, several influencers are drawing investor funds for own brands across food, beauty and supplements

Disha Acharya & Pranav Mukul

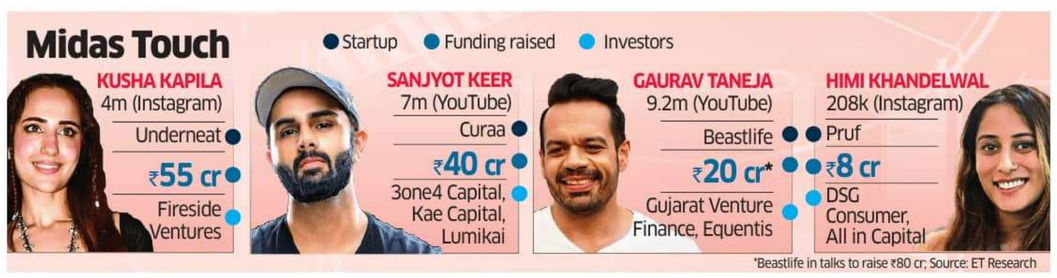
Bengaluru: Social media creators across beauty, fashion, food and supplements are increasingly turning their influence and expertise into consumer brands, attracting venture capital funding for their startups in a move that echoes the rise of celebrity-backed businesses.

Beauty and skincare content creator Himi Khandelwal, also known as The Skintellectual Girl with 208,000 followers on Instagram, has raised about ₹8 crore at a pre-money valuation of ₹22 crore for her skincare brand Pruf, led by DSG Consumer, with participation from All In Capital, and angels like Reckitt's Arjun Purkayastha, Snapdeal founders Kunal Bahl and Rohit Bansal, Shaadi.com's Anupam Mittal, and Deconstruct founder Malini Adapureddy, people aware of the development said.

Similarly, chef Sanjyot Keer, who has been running his channel Your Food Lab on YouTube for the past decade and has over 7 million followers, raised ₹40 crore for his home appliance brand Curaa, led by 3one4 Capital earlier this week.

Over the past year, Instagram influencer and creator Kusha Kapila's shapewear brand Underneat has raised almost $7 million from Fireside Ventures and Alteria Capital while vlogger and former pilot Gaurav Taneja's supplement brand Beastlife is talks to raise ₹80 crore funding, sources told ET. It raised ₹20 crore from GVFL and Equentis at a ₹320 million valuation in April this year. "We are starting with concerns faced by Indian skin, beginning with hyperpigmentation," Khandelwal, cofounder and CEO of Pruf, told ET.

Familiar Territory ▸▸ 7



MODI TO MEET CENTRAL ASIAN LEADERS IN KYRGYZSTAN

Plans Afoot for Modi, Xi Meet at SCO, to Set Stage for India Visit

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: PM Narendra Modi is expected to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping in Bishkek (Kyrgyzstan) on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit early next week, ahead of Xi's visit to India for the BRICS Summit on September 12-13.

The Bishkek meet will help prepare for the Modi-Xi meet in New Delhi that could steadily rebuild economic partnership. The meeting here will be substantive and may result in concrete outcomes, according to a person familiar with the Sino-India ties.

At the SCO Summit on Monday, the PM will highlight the need for stronger measures to combat international terror and push for inclusive connectivity initiatives in Eurasia.

Modi to push for stronger action against terrorism and inclusive connectivity at SCO Summit

Advancing financial mechanisms, including the proposed SCO Development Bank and Investment Fund, will also be on the summit agenda.

India's focus at SCO over the years has been on strengthening mechanisms to counter cross-border terror and dismantling terror infrastructure in the Eurasian and Af-Pak region. Central Asian states have been worried over the growing network of cross-border extremists in Eurasia. SCO is the only regional organisation that has a dedicated body — RATS — on counter-terrorism.

On the sideline of the SCO Summit, Modi is also expected to meet several Eurasian leaders. Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and Belarus will attend the BRICS Summit.

PM Narendra Modi with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev on his arrival in Tashkent on Saturday. –IANS

INNOPROM.INDIA TO SHOWCASE RUSSIAN TECH AND BIZ OPPORTUNITIES

Modi, Putin to Visit Delhi Industrial Trade Fair Ahead of BRICS Summit

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: The first mega India-Russia International Industrial Trade Fair 'INNOPROM.India' will be held during September 9-11 here ahead of the 18th BRICS Summit. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin are expected to visit the exposition.

The exhibition is expected to provide new opportunities for direct business engagement, technology partnerships and the development of joint industrial projects between the two countries, people familiar with the matter said. Putin will be visiting India to attend the September 12-13 BRICS Summit.

The planned visit to the exposition by Modi and Putin underscores the high level of attention attached to the development of bilateral industrial and economic cooperation, experts on India-Russia ties said.

The exhibition will focus on areas such as mechanical engineering, chemicals, digital technologies, mining and extraction technologies, human-centric technologies and the development of bilateral trade and industrial cooperation, people familiar with the event said.

Russian exhibitors will showcase their latest developments and technological solutions. Among the exhibits will be a model of a nuclear power plant equipped with a VVER-1200 reactor unit, as well as composite products designed for the storage, use and transportation of gas. The exposition will also showcase master alloys and powders made from rare and rare-earth metals, along with models of modern Russian aircraft and helicopters, the people said.

FOUR INDIANS TRAPPED AT A HYDROPOWER PROJECT IN RASUWA RESCUED

Nepal Flash Floods: Death Toll Reaches 669

ANI | OPB

Kathmandu & New Delhi: The death toll in the devastating Rasuwa-Bhote Koshi flash floods has risen to 669 as of 4 pm on Saturday, according to the Nepal Police.

Emergency response teams deployed downstream have retrieved bodies across several districts, with the highest number recorded in Chitwan, where 248 bodies have been found, the police said.

Significant casualties have also been reported in Nawalparasi East, where 158 bodies have been recovered, followed by Nawalparasi West with 75, Gorkha with 54, Dhading with 49, Nuwakot with 41, Tanahun with 31, and Rasuwa with 13.

In addition to the fatalities, a total of 2,301 individuals have been rescued or treated for injuries across the affected areas, the police updated.

Nuwakot leads the regional rescue figures with 1,622 individuals saved, followed by 676 in Rasuwa and three in Dhading. Medical facilities across the Kathmandu Valley have treated or discharged 140 injured flood survivors who were transferred for advanced care.

Search and rescue operations remain on high alert as 27 police personnel remain out of contact following the disaster. To manage ongoing operations, locate the missing, and secure affected communities, Nepal Police have deployed 4,854 security personnel across the disaster zone.

Additionally, India's Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) confirmed in an official update issued that four Indian nationals trapped at a hydropower project in Rasuwa were rescued today as search and emergency operations intensify across Nepal following catastrophic flash flooding.

An aerial view of damaged structures in Nuwakot, Nepal –PTI

Centre Speeds Up Work on Early Warning Systems for 188 Himalayan Lakes

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Centre is stepping up efforts to set up early warning systems (EWS) across 188 critical lakes in the Indian Himalayan Region (IHR) that are vulnerable to glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs). The push has gained urgency following the devastating floods that have killed more than 600 people on both sides of the Nepal-Tibet border.

Between 1990 and 2018, the number and surface area of glacial lakes increased 53% and 51%, respectively, a government official said, citing scientific studies.

"While these water bodies are often strikingly beautiful, they represent a growing hazard. (As many as) 15 million people worldwide live under the threat of GLOFs, and more than half of this exposed population resides in just four countries — India, Pakistan, Peru and China," the official explained.

Recent incidents of GLOFs that triggered catastrophic flooding include the South Lhonak GLOF in Sikkim on October 4, 2023, and Nepal's Thyanbo glacial lake on August 16, 2024, which devastated the village of Thame in the Khumbu Region. "Together, these incidents highlighted that GLOFs are not isolated or localised phenomena — they are part of a broader pattern of cryosphere-linked disasters in the Hindu Kush Himalaya," the official said.

Leading earth sciences institutions such as NRSC, CWC, GSI, ICIMOD, UNDP, SDC and NSIDC have mapped more than 7,500 glacial lakes across the Ganga, Brahmaputra and Indus basins. Many of them pose increasing downstream risks.

Jarange Begins 11th Fast, Threatens Stir in Mumbai

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: Maratha leader Manoj Jarange Patil began his 11th hunger strike in his village Antarvali Sarati in Jalna, seeking OBC caste certificates for Marathas, who are considered upper castes, among other demands.

Jarange Patil has now called for the disbanding of the Caste Verification Committee that verifies caste certificates. He has threatened to take his agitation to Mumbai if his demands are not accepted.

"This is our final battle, this time we will get all our demands accepted, if the government does not accept our demands then we will go and protest in Varsha (Chief Minister's official residence in Mumbai) or Azad Maidan. The people of Mumbai should bear with us."

Maratha leader wants caste verification committee disbanded

Jarange Patil wants Marathas to be given Kunbi (OBC) caste certificates based on the Hyderabad Gazette, under which certain Marathas were classified as Kunbis. Jarange claims that there are 58 lakh such records of Maratha families and wants entire families to be issued such caste certificates based on these records.

The OBC community has opposed Jarange Patil's demands, saying they could make the OBC pool, which is already crowded with several communities vying for reservation benefits, more congested.

Centre to Hold Ministerial-level Talks on Naga Peace Issue: Rio

The decision had been communicated to the Naga negotiating groups, says CM

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio said Union Home Minister Amit Shah had agreed to have the Union Ministers of State for Home Affairs engage with the Naga political groups involved in negotiations.

Rio said in Nagaland that the decision had been communicated to the Naga negotiating groups and that the process was currently underway.

Rio recently met Shah in New Delhi.

AK Mishra, Advisor to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) on Northeast affairs, has so far held a series of talks with various Naga groups, including the Isak-Muivah faction of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN-IM). Former Nagaland Governor R.N. Ravi was the interlocutor in the Naga peace talks before he took charge as Tamil Nadu Governor in September 2021.

The Centre and NSCN-IM are holding peace parleys. There is a stalemate between the government of India and NSCN-IM over the contentious issue of a separate flag and Constitution. NSCN-IM has been demanding a separate flag and Constitution, which the government of India has rejected.

The Political Affairs Committee (PAC) of the Nagaland government had urged in 2025 that the Centre elevate the Naga peace talks to the highest political level by appointing an interlocutor of political or ministerial rank with the confidence and mandate of the government.

The PAC, headed by Rio, had resolved that the peace talks be resumed at the political level to expedite the negotiation process.

HALDWANI INCIDENT

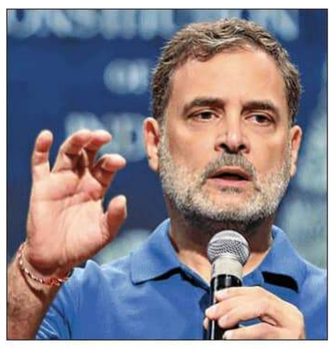
Rahul Seeks FIR Over 'Purification' Act

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi order the filing of an FIR under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act against those who conducted a "purification act" at the Ramlila Ground in Haldwani after Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there. He also sought an FIR against Uttarakhand BJP president Mahendra Bhatt, who 'justified 'the act.

Saying that Union minister JP Nadda's promise in the Rajya Sabha of action against those involved in the Haldwani incident remained unfulfilled, Gandhi indicated that the Congress would respond with a larger agitation if the demand was not met.

Terming the "purification" act nothing but the practice of untouchability, Gandhi said at a press conference: "This (purification) act violates the SC/ST Act. Performing a 'purification' ritual is a crime. Yet, no action has been taken ... The Prime Minister claims to belong to every caste and to be the Prime Minister of all of India. Yet, the chief of his (Uttarakhand) party states that the purification was justified."



Gandhi, who recently held a dharna at a Delhi police station to get an alleged victim of pellet firing to file an FIR, added: "It is the duty of both the state government and the central government to ensure that Kharge ji receives justice in Uttarakhand...Now the ball is in their court. If they take the action that ought to be taken, very good. If they do not take action, then there will certainly be a reaction from us."

The Congress leader said he did not care about the silence of Modi or BSP leader Mayawati on the issue.

Rahul Lying, Even Haldwani Valmikis Say So: BJP

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The BJP on Saturday hit out at Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition (LoP) in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, accusing them of lying with regard to claims of an alleged purification ritual at an event addressed by Kharge in Uttarakhand's Haldwani.

BJP leader Gourav Vallabh said: "People of Haldwani's Valmiki community are themselves admitting that Rahul is lying and attempting to spread a political hoax in order to gain the votes."

BJP National Spokesperson Shri Guru Prakash Paswan said: " The Congress and Rahul Gandhi's claims on Dalit respect are under scrutiny due to their own history and conduct. The Congress today speaks of honoring Kharge ji, but a picture from Priyanka Vadra's nomination in Wayanad raised questions, when the party's national president Kharge was seen standing outside."

Statement

Kumar Anshuman & Bikash Singh

Patnaik Urges Odisha BJP MPs to Oppose Mines Bill

Former Odisha CM Naveen Patnaik on Saturday appealed to all BJP MPs from the state to demand the reversal of the mining bill passed by Parliament on August 13.

Calling it a "black day", Patnaik questioned the BJP MPs over their support for the bill. In a letter addressed to all BJP MPs from Odisha, Patnaik said the legislation would have a far-reaching impact on the state, which owns 44% of India's mineral wealth.

"The estimated annual loss would be more than ₹12,000 cro leading to lakhs of crores of rupees over time. But the bigger loss is that in a single legislative stroke the control over our own minerals and our mineral bearing lands was taken away from us. This law is an injustice to the children and youth of Odisha," Patnaik wrote in the letter.

Patnaik urged the MPs to press for the withdrawal of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026.

Jharkhand had earlier also raised objections to the MMDR Bill passed by Parliament, with state CM Hemant Soren writing to the PM with a similar appeal.

VARANI SAHU

Akhilesh-Jayant Sparring Takes Caste Turn in UP

Ahead of the assembly elections, a fierce war of words has erupted between Samajwadi Party leader Akhilesh Yadav and RLD leader Jayant Choudhary, gradually turning into a battle over caste identity.

During the last assembly election, when asked about a possible switch, Choudhary had remarked that he was not a 'chavanni' (small coin) who would switch sides. However, before the Lok Sabha elections, Choudhary joined the NDA. Yadav, in a recent comment, said he had made 'chavanni' a rupee, but "they left".

RLD supporters portrayed the remark as an insult to the Jats to which Choudhary belongs. Choudhary too expressed his displeasure in a post on X.

"If you had to use cheap words, you could have at least said them taking my name, it wouldn't have been an issue... Targeting the Jat community and saying ABCD we taught? I've seen this arrogance up close and I believe such behaviour only brings downfall," he posted on X.

The exchanges intensified recently after the murder of Haryana singer Ankit Balyan, when Akhilesh attacked the BJP government over law and order and again framed the issue in caste terms.

"The BJP is only for your votes. Have the BJP's allied Jat leaders gone underground?" Yadav said.

Choudhary responded, saying: "In a heinous crime like murder, seeking out the caste of the deceased and saying that people of his caste are enraged is, in itself, a display of insensitivity."

BJP Faces TMC Rebels' Dilemma Ahead of Kolkata Civic Election

In Parliament, the Lok Sabha Speaker has made separate seating arrangements for the 20 rebel TMC MPs who have merged with NCPI. However, the Speaker is yet to take a call on their demand to recognise NCPI as a separate parliamentary party. The MPs are attending NDA meetings as NCPI and as an ally of the BJP.

The development has created another dilemma for the BJP in West Bengal. NCPI leader Sudip Bandyopadhyay, while speaking at an event, said the party would contest the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) elections as an NDA constituent.

NCPI's plan to contest KMC polls as NDA ally puts Bengal BJP in a bind, with leaders denying any alliance

Fearing a backlash from its core supporters, West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya and Union minister Sukanta Majumdar denied any such plan.

The party fears that voters and a section of its workers could turn against it as they were not in favour of aligning with a group that was part of the TMC and against which they had fought continuously.

The situation for NCPI is manageable in Delhi as there is no Lok Sabha or assembly election in the near future. But the BJP will have to define NCPI's role in state politics, and that is where the party finds itself in a fix for now.

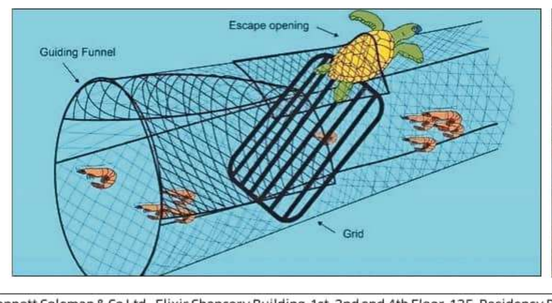
Gujarat Aims to Catch US Shrimp Orders With Turtle-safe Nets

DP Bhattacharya

Gandhinagar: The Gujarat government is set to install turtle excluder devices (TEDs) in fishermen's fishing nets, which it expects would help address the reason cited by the US for banning imports of wild-caught shrimp from India.

The move is aimed at boosting Gujarat's seafood exports to the US and other global markets, state fisheries minister Jitu Vaghani said. Under this initiative, 8,925 fishermen in the state will receive TED free of cost with government assistance. The ₹20.96 crore project will help protect marine biodiversity and create greater opportunities for the state's seafood industry in global markets, Vaghani said.

The US banned import of wild-caught shrimp from India citing concerns about commercial fishing equipment causing injury and death to sea turtles. Use of TED is expected to reduce this risk and make it easier to obtain international certifications required for exports.



According to the state government, Gujarat received the approval for the highest number of TED units among states under a central programme.

The Central Institute of Fisheries Technology in Kochi, which comes under the Indian Council of Agricultural Research, developed the specialised TED model in line with standards set by the US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration.

This device is a special mechanism fitted into shrimp trawl nets. It allows shrimp to be retained while giving larger marine animals, such as sea turtles, a safe escape route through an exit flap. This device is expected to significantly reduce sea turtle deaths during fishing operations.

National Sports Day

Union Minister for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal bats while Union Minister for Labour Mansukh L Mandaviya bowls during a match organised on National Sports Day at a stadium in New Delhi on Saturday—PTI

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GST Council to Hold 57th Meet on Sept 12

REFORMS PIPELINE Easing blocked input tax credit, simplifying GST treatment of corp guarantees on the agenda

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The GST Council is set to meet on September 12, nearly a year after its last meeting, to consider reforms including making it easier to get blocked input tax credit (ITC), simplifying the GST treatment of corporate guarantees and allowing small businesses to register in multiple states.

The 57th meeting of the Council will be held in New Delhi, with the meeting of tax officers scheduled for September 11, according to an official communication issued by the GST Council Secretariat.

A key proposal is protecting buyers from losing input tax credit (ITC) if suppliers fail to deposit taxes with the government, said people familiar with the deliberations.

In such cases, it is proposed that buyers will get ITC if they establish that the payment, including the GST component, was made through banking channels or other prescribed payment documents.

The GST Council may also consider relaxing existing provisions to allow companies to claim ITC on vehicles purchased in the company's name for employees' use and on group health and life insurance policies bought for employees.

The Council may also examine the GST framework for corporate guarantees provided within a group, with businesses seeking greater clarity and a simpler approach to valuation and taxation of such arrangements.

Another possible area of discussion is allowing multiple-state GST registration for small businesses, which could help enterprises operating across states streamline compliance and reduce the administrative burden associated with maintaining separate registrations.

Businesses are also looking for movement on refund norms, unutilised ITC and other issues that have remained unresolved, particularly those affecting working capital and compliance costs.

The proposals are part of the committee's ease of doing business review and are expected to be considered at the next GST Council meeting

The proposals are part of the committee's ease of doing business review and are expected to be considered at the next GST Council meeting.

Experts say the next phase of reforms should reinforce GST's core objective of making the tax regime simpler, more predictable and easier to comply with.

"The upcoming GST Council meeting is an opportunity to inject fresh momentum into the reform agenda after nearly a year, with businesses looking for greater certainty on issues that have remained unresolved for far too long," said Manoj Mishra, partner and tax controversy management leader, Grant Thornton Bharat.

The focus, he said, should now shift from incremental changes to improving the quality of the GST framework itself.

Corporates have also flagged the need for a mechanism to regularise legacy tax positions, particularly in online gaming, and address genuine ITC hardships arising from supplier defaults.

"Equally important is reducing interpretational ambiguities that continue to drive avoidable litigation and compliance costs," Mishra said.

In the last GST Council meeting, the council had cleared GST 2.0.

The Centre has proposed GST 2.0, with a two-tier tax slab of 5% and 18%, doing away with the tax slab of 12% and 28%, and a special slab of 40% for the sin goods, limiting it to five to seven items.

ADDRESSING DEFICIT

India Weighing Steps to Help Nepal with More Power

Nepal, which has been hit by floods, has sought advance import approvals from Sept

Shilpa Samant

New Delhi: Indian authorities are processing requests to facilitate increased power flow to Nepal in accordance with established frameworks, including trade through the day-ahead market and the real-time market segments of Indian power exchanges, people aware of the development said.

Nepal has sought advance import approvals effective September to mitigate generation deficits caused by recent flash floods, one of the people said. The request is for importing electricity earlier than usual—Nepal traditionally imports electricity from India during the lean or winter months starting October, the person added.

India will provide power to Nepal as per their needs, the people cited earlier said. India also imports power from Nepal. While the flash floods in the Trishuli and Lhende Khola river basin on August 26 caused severe infrastructural damage including to power generation units in Nepal, the impact on India's national power grid is minimal and fully manageable, said industry executives.

Nepal's domestic generation capacity has fallen by around 550 MW due to the damaged facilities, an executive said. Cross-border power flow to India is currently reduced by around 400 MW from its previous peak export levels of around 950-1,000 MW, the executive said.

"We do not foresee any requirement for exceptional emergency procurement or alternative arrangements to balance domestic demand (because of the shortfall)," a power ministry official said. "India's vast national grid capacity and robust generation reserve margins are capable of absorbing a temporary shortfall of 400 MW seamlessly without disrupting grid stability or retail supply."

Major cross-border transmission corridors, such as the high-capacity 400 kV Dhalkebar–Muzaffarpur link, with a transfer capacity of 1,000 MW, remain operational, the industry executive cited earlier said.

Key projects developed by Indian public sector undertakings in Nepal, including the under-construction 900 MW Arun-3 and 669 MW Lower Arun projects in the Arun River basin, are located in an unaffected area and continue on schedule without disruption, said the people.

Ather Bets On Its Mass-Mkt Scooter to Boost Margins

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: Ather Energy expects its new Konarc electric scooter to deliver better gross margins than its popular Rizta within a year, as the company bets on a lower-cost platform to take products into the mass market and improve profitability, cofounder and chief executive Tarun Mehta said. Ather launched Konarc on Saturday at a starting price of ₹1 lakh, making it the first product built on its new EL platform. Mehta said the company plans to build several scooters on the platform over the next few years.

"In a year's time, Konarc should yield higher gross margins than Rizta. It'll take a few quarters for the margins to flow through the entire operations," Mehta told ET in an interview. The margin advantage will come from several changes under EL, including a steel frame, a lower-cost but more durable transmission and a redesigned electronics system, he said.

Ather launched Konarc on Saturday at a starting price of ₹1 lakh, making it the first product built on its new EL platform

"We couldn't have launched a ₹1 lakh Rizta without losing money. But we can build a ₹1 lakh Konarc and still have a healthy margin," he said. "Scaling the supply chain behind a cast aluminium frame is a lot harder than scaling the supply behind a steel one. So steel, in many ways, made more sense for a mainstream product."

On competing with larger players such as Bajaj and TVS Motor in the mass-market category, Mehta said Ather's strategy will be to play to its strengths rather than compete on scale and distribution.

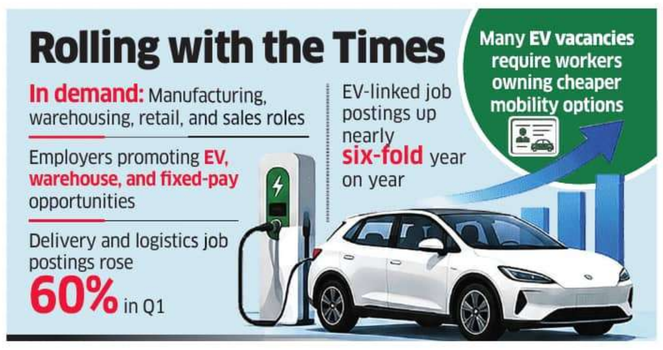
Surging Fuel and Vehicle Costs Reshape Gig Hiring as Workers Chase Better Economics

Delivery workers seek predictable earnings while employers step up incentive plans

Neil Ghai & Prachi Verma

New Delhi: Rising fuel and vehicle operating costs are making India's gig workers more selective about the jobs they take, with many opting for roles that offer predictable earnings or lower running costs. This is prompting employers to expand incentives, EV-linked opportunities and fixed-pay jobs to attract and retain delivery workers, recruitment experts said.

The available talent pool for delivery-based gig roles has contracted by 5-10% over the past four months, said Deepesh Gupta, head of business, general staffing, at Adecco India. This does not mean workers are becoming unemployed. Instead, they are moving into manufacturing, warehousing, retail and sales jobs that offer more predictable earnings or lower work-related costs, he said. "Gig workers are highly mobile and typically transition across frontline sectors based on overall income potential and job viability," Gupta said.



Apna.co's data show that job postings in delivery, driver and logistics roles rose 60% year-on-year in the first quarter of FY27, while vacancies offering lower operating costs or greater income certainty saw much stronger growth. Electric vehicle-related job postings surged 593% year-on-year, warehouse jobs grew 91% and fixed-pay opportunities expanded 205%.

More significantly, these jobs attracted much greater interest from candidates. EV postings received 62.5% more candidates per opening than the overall delivery segment, fixed-pay roles 244% more, and warehouse jobs 350% more, Apna data showed. "For workers...the distinction between headline earning potential and guaranteed income is becoming increasingly important," Kartik Narayan, chief executive of jobs marketplace at Apna.co, said.

Petrol prices have risen by around ₹7.5 a litre since the Iran-US conflict began in February, increasing operating expenses on home delivery services, which delivery partners bear themselves in most cases.

Putting further pressure on such workers, union road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari told parliament last month that ethanol blending in petrol can reduce fuel efficiency by 2-6%, depending on the vehicle and its age.

For employers, this is raising the cost of keeping delivery workers on the road. Employers of gig workers, including Flipkart, Eternal, Swiggy and Uber India, had not responded to ET's email queries until press time on Saturday.

IGL Raises CNG Prices in Delhi By Nearly ₹4

New Delhi: Indraprastha Gas (IGL) has raised the price of compressed natural gas (CNG) by ₹3.89 per kg in Delhi and its nearly 20 other licensed areas from Sunday. The move is aimed at offsetting higher gas procurement costs after the Iran war caused global gas benchmarks to double. In Delhi, CNG is being retailed at ₹86.98 per kg. Since the beginning of the Iran war six months ago, CNG prices in Delhi are up by a cumulative ₹9.89, including ₹6 raised previously.

Taxi and autorickshaws, which are largely CNG-powered in the national capital region, have already passed on the previous CNG cost increase to end-customers. The fresh increase may further raise fares. The Iran war has cut off liquefied natural gas (LNG) supplies from Qatar, one of the world's largest suppliers, resulting in a sharp spike in global prices. — **Our Bureau**

OpenAI Plans to Stop Supplying AI Models to SpaceX-Owned Cursor

OpenAI says it is not confident SpaceX will use their tech within terms of service based on experience with Musk cos

Reuters

OpenAI said on Friday that it plans to stop providing AI models to Cursor, the coding-tool company now owned by Elon Musk's SpaceX, marking a further escalation in the bitter rivalry between OpenAI CEO Sam Altman and Musk.

Musk and Altman have been at odds for years, a feud that culminated earlier this year in a trial over Musk's $150 billion lawsuit against OpenAI. During the trial, Musk's lawyer said that Musk and other witnesses had testified that Altman was a liar, while OpenAI argued that Musk had sought control of the company.

"We are making this choice because we cannot be confident that SpaceX will use our technology within our terms of service, based on our experience with Elon Musk's companies violating contracts," OpenAI said in a blog post.

Musk responded early on Saturday in an X post, writing, "I couldn't care less."

He accused Altman and OpenAI president Greg Brockman of being "untrustworthy," while repeating his assertion that they "stole an open source nonprofit."

Musk, the world's richest person, had sued OpenAI and Altman for "stealing a charity" by betraying the company's original nonprofit mission for their own enrichment. A federal jury ruled against Musk earlier this year, finding that he had filed the case too late.

However, Michael Truell, a co-founder of Cursor and now an executive at SpaceX, said on X that the company was speaking with the OpenAI team to resolve this issue.

Hours after OpenAI's announcement, Anthropic, which rivals both firms but has an ongoing partnership with SpaceX, said it planned to increase compute to support Claude models in Cursor, according to Tom Brown, one of the co-founders of the firm.

A FIGHT

Elon Musk and Sam Altman have been at odds for years, a feud that culminated earlier this year in a trial over Musk's $150 billion lawsuit against OpenAI

In its blog post, OpenAI said that X, formerly known as Twitter and now part of SpaceX, had breached the terms of its contract with OpenAI after Musk acquired the platform.

"To work with a large partner like SpaceX, we typically rely on custom contracts to ensure compliance with our terms of service and that the integration provides for safety at scale," the AI company added.

The ChatGPT-maker said it proposed a shutoff date of November 12, 2026, adding that its agreement with Cursor gave it a limited time window to cancel the contract following "a change of control."

AFP

Writers United!

Actors operating giant puppets depicting Russian writers and thinkers Alexander Pushkin (R), Nikolai Gogol (M) and Fyodor Dostoevsky (L) perform on a street in Saint Petersburg on Saturday

Max Estates to Buy Land in Delhi for ₹420 cr

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Max Estates, the real estate arm of the Max Group, has entered into a share-purchase agreement to acquire 84.7 acres of land in West Delhi. The acquisition is structured as a non-cash, share-swap transaction wherein Max Estates will issue up to 7 million equity shares at ₹597.5 each, or ₹420.2 crore, to the shareholders of the companies that own the land, Max Estates said in a news release on Saturday.

Max Estates shares ended at ₹539.00 on the BSE Friday.

The acquisition will unlock ₹10,000-12,000 crore gross development value (GDV) for the company, the news release said. The land is acquired at ₹4.95 crore per acre, materially below prevailing licensed land values, the company said. The cost is estimated under 5% of GDV versus a typical 20-25% for land purchases in cash, it added. "This transaction gives us our first foothold in Delhi—the one core NCR market we did not yet have a presence in—at a fraction of prevailing land values elsewhere in the region, and without deploying a rupee of cash," Max Estates vice chairman and managing director Sahil Vachani said.

Max Estates will acquire 100% in the companies that own the land as one integrated transaction by issuing shares on a preferential basis. On completion of the deal, these companies will become wholly-owned subsidiaries of Max Estates. Max Estates currently has a residential pipeline of ₹16,150 crore of GDV from the ongoing second quarter of this fiscal year. The proposed transaction will extend Max Estates' residential footprint beyond Noida and Gurugram into Delhi, which offers the least available sizeable land parcels in the National Capital Territory.

VC Co Andreessen Horowitz Raises $1B for AI Infra Fund

Bloomberg

Prominent venture capital firm Andreessen Horowitz says it has raised $1.1 billion for its newest artificial intelligence infrastructure fund. The "Machine Age Fund" will invest in AI computer infrastructure such as chips, memory, networking and storage, firm said on Friday, and will also include data centers, robotics and home appliances.

In an interview with Bloomberg News, Andreessen Horowitz general partner Raghu Raghuram said that the fund, which is a haul of new capital instead of a carve-out of the firm's $15 billion venture fund from earlier this year, is a response to the demand for more physical technology to support AI startups' needs. The firm argues that advances from AI workloads are driving dramatic increases in computing demand and creating bottlenecks across existing hardware and supply chains.

"If you walk around San Francisco, talk to any company: They'll tell you that the only thing holding them back is a lack of AI computing capacity," Raghuram said. The new fund will primarily be invested into early stage startups, with some capital reserved for more mature companies. Raghuram, who previously served as the chief executive officer of major cloud infrastructure company VMware, said Andreessen Horowitz decided to raise a new, separate fund because physical investments often come with different needs, including unique underwriting and larger initial capital requirements.

"These companies have to turn design into a prototype of a chip or networking system," he said. "And that takes quite a bit of money." He pointed to recent deals like AI startup Groq's reported $20 billion licensing deal with Nvidia and AI infra company Cerebras Systems's public debut as an example of how, despite larger capital needs, there are timely exits for successful tech.

FSSAI Bans 2 Firms Over 'Sub-standard' Hing Powder

PTI

New Delhi: Food regulator FSSAI on Saturday said it has prohibited Everest Food Products and Laljee Godhoo from selling hing powder, which it found to be sub-standard. In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that it has issued prohibition orders against Everest Food Products and Laljee Godhoo and Company as their products 'hing powder' were found to be sub-standard. In case of Everest, FSSAI has prohibited sale of compounded asafoetida variants with immediate effect. "The samples of compounded asafoetida (hing powder) were found to be 'misbranded and sub-standard' by the food analyst of the primary food laboratory," the regulator said. The articles were found to be in contravention of the provisions of the FSS (Food Products and Food Additives) Regulations, 2011.

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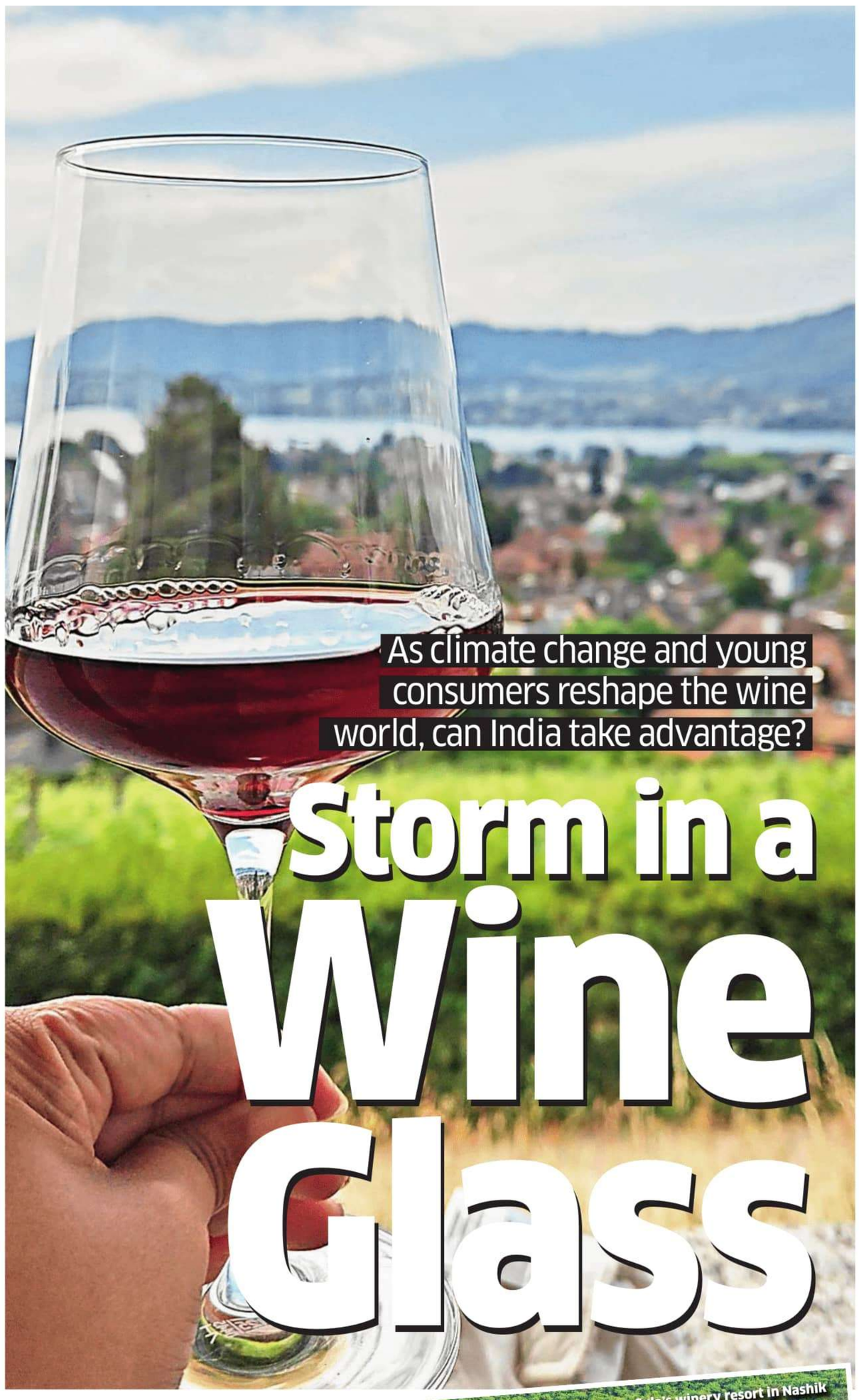
As climate change and young consumers reshape the wine world, can India take advantage?

Storm in a Wine Glass



Garima Verma

The wine world is changing. For the traditionalists, a bit too fast. For the progressives, perhaps not fast enough. While they debate whether wine is a cultured ritual or a casual convenience, climate change has entered and overwhelmed the conversation. No longer a looming threat, it is rewriting the global wine playbook.

As old bastions face challenges, unlikely places emerge as destinations for wines and related experiences. Georgia is reviving and building tourism around orange wine. China is doing viticulture, from Ningxia to high-altitude Yunnan. Even English sparkling wines are getting recognised. From Australia moving beyond Shiraz, to Germany doubling down on new-age methods, wine has indeed gone global. Can India take advantage as the wine map gets redrawn?

In India, people are not just swigging more wine, but they are also drinking in the vineyards. Rajeev Samant, founder and CEO of Sula Vineyards, says its revenue from wine tourism has crossed ₹100 crore. "Today our vineyards and resorts welcome over 400,000 visitors each year. Our wine tourism business has grown rapidly, seeing a strong double-digit growth over the last five-six years, and crossing the ₹100 crore revenue mark for the first time in FY2026," he says. Sula Vineyards, which unveiled its third resort in Nashik, the wine capital of the country, in 2025, has signed an agreement to acquire Chandon's 19-acre estate to expand its tourism footprint. Samant says the stay at Sula's estates is driven by affluent millennials.

The wine tourism market is flourishing globally even when other areas are languishing. According to Persistence Market Research, the global wine tourism market is expected to be $57.4 billion in 2026 and could reach $138.4 billion by 2033, a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 13.4%. Driven by a rising middle-class and expanding wine tourism infrastructure, Asia Pacific is growing fastest at 15.2%.

RED ALERT

Meanwhile, the traditional wine regions in Europe are battling multiple issues—falling demand, drought, water stress and reduced yields. Topping it all was the heatwave that rattled the continent this summer. Wildfires and smoke have impacted the wine-growing regions of Bordeaux and Provence in France. It has been a harsh warning on how Europe could be affected by climate change and rising temperatures.

France is the second biggest wine producer in the world, with yields of 35-37 million hectolitres (mhl, 1 hectolitre = 100 litres). Temperatures in French vineyards have risen by 3°C since 1980.

In the report, State of the World Wine Sector, released in May by the International Organisation of Vine and Wine (OIV), the global wine consumption in 2025 was 208 mhl, a fall of 2.7% from 2024 and the lowest since 1957. The global wine production of 227 mhl in 2025 was only slightly above (0.6%) the historical low of 2024.

"The 2025 vineyard surface represents a small reduction of 0.8% compared to 2024. While relatively minor, this is the sixth consecutive year that the world vineyard area has decreased in size," said John Barker, director general of OIV. The fall in Europe's vineyard area was primarily driven by significant removals of grapevines in France and, to some extent, Spain.

Though India's wine consumption is low, at less than 1% of the alcoholic beverage market, it has been growing at a CAGR of 25% over the past decade

An article in the online journal Nature Reviews Earth & Environment issues a dire warning: "About 90% of traditional wine regions in coastal and lowland regions of Spain, Italy, Greece and southern California could be at risk of disappearing by the end of the century because of excessive drought and more frequent heatwaves with climate change."

By contrast, India's vineyards have been expanding at an average of 4.6% since 2019. In 2025, the total area under vines was 1,97,000 hectares, the seventh largest in the world. However, there is a catch: only around 3,000 hectares are growing wine grapes, with the rest dedicated to the production of table grapes and raisins. It shows both the limits and potential of India.

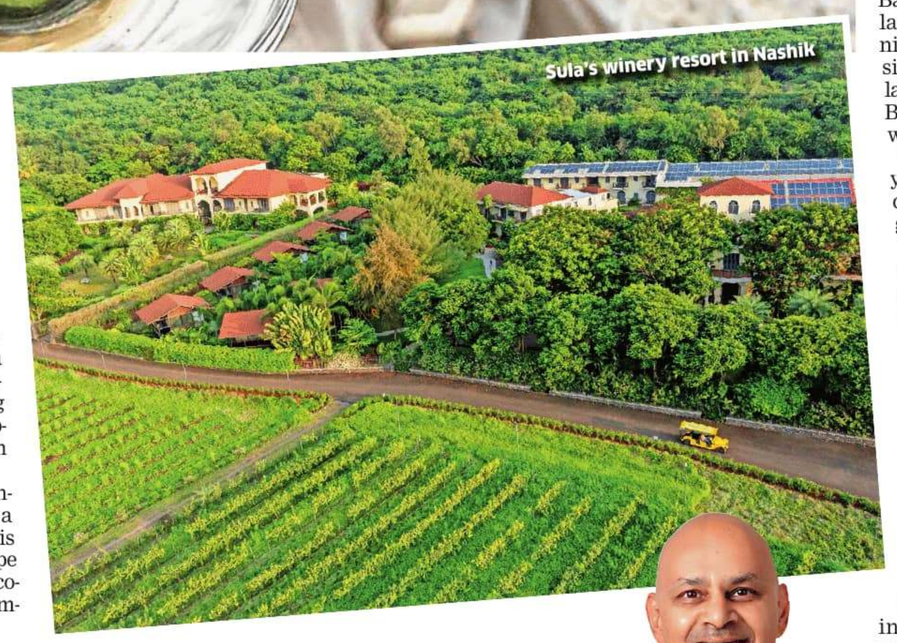
NEW WORLDS

As leading regions struggle, newer worlds are seeing an opportunity. A case in point: OIV is holding its World Congress of Vine and Wine in China this October, underlining the shifting trends in the oeno-universe.

Says Sula's Samant: "Consumers have evolved. They are shunning Old World archetypes that suited a region, like the room temperature rule, and are not shying away from enjoying their wine the way they like, chilled or otherwise." Sula, India's largest wine producer, holds over 50% of the domestic market share, with its Shiraz Cabernet the highest selling and grossing wine.

Though India's wine consumption is low, at less than 1% of the alcoholic beverage market, it has been growing at a CAGR of 25% over the past decade, according to the Indian Grape Processing Board. Meanwhile, the global consumption has declined steadily since 2018, with volumes falling by 14%.

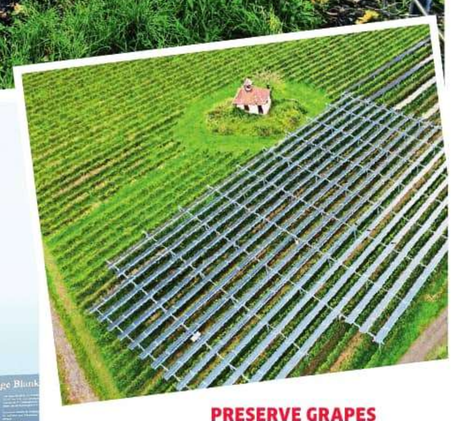
While millennials are the leading consumers, it is Gen Z that is forcing a change. The sober-curious generation is making the industry push the envelope on sustainability, organic wines and alcohol-free and low-alcohol options, and immersive wine-led experiences.



Sula's winery resort in Nashik

Today our vineyards and resorts welcome over 400,000 visitors each year. Revenue from our wine tourism business crossed ₹100 crore for the first time in FY2026"
RAJEEV SAMANT, founder, Sula Vineyards

The state wine estate in Freiburg, Germany, has installed viti-photovoltaic systems that not only produce electricity but also protect grapes from extreme heat as well as hail and heavy rains



Martin Linser is the head of Competence Center for Viticulture 4.0, an experimental platform that helps small and medium-sized wine estates in Germany handle climate change

Future vineyards will move from reactive farming to predictive farming—where sensors measure, AI interprets and the grower acts before the problem becomes visible"
MANJUNATH VG, vice-president, viticulture, Grover Zampa Vineyards

"It is not that wine has fallen out of fashion among the young, but the way it is marketed to them needs to change," says 25-year-old Abhiroop Ray, restaurant manager and sommelier at Captain's Cellar, the wine lounge at the Taj Mahal hotel in Delhi. He points to the changing tastes: "Our legacy customers still prefer established producers from Bordeaux and Burgundy, or a Barolo from Italy. The younger crowd, in the late 20s or early 30s, is more receptive to niche producers, small estates, blends from single varietals, organic wines and quirky labels." He is in the process of adding Panic Button from Spain's Yecla region and crisp wines from Austria.

The change is reflected in travel, with younger oenophiles favouring offbeat, unconventional and up-and-coming wine regions over legacy estates.

Skyscanner's Travel Trends Report 2026 showed a 105% increase in Indian travellers searching for Tbilisi as a destination—Georgia's 8,000-year-old subterranean wine culture and its claim as the birthplace of winemaking have played quite a part in that.

Wine tourists are becoming climate conscious too. Surveys in the Global Wine Tourism Report 2025 show that 84% of visitors think sustainability is relevant. Meanwhile, 92% of wineries believe sustainability will be important for wine tourism.

Wines that are low on travel footprint are championing the cause of local producers. For instance, many who sit down at Restaurant Sonnenberg in Zurich, overlooking its micro-vineyard, opt for its own Pinot Noir Stadt Zürich aus den Sonnenberg Reden. However, Swiss growers are struggling—consumption in the country has fallen almost 20% in two decades while vineyard area has remained steady, leading to overproduction.

PRESERVE GRAPES

Europe is trying to keep pace with changing times and demands. The Staatsweingut or the state wine estate in Freiburg, Germany, engages in organic viticulture. Keeping an eye on young consumers, it is producing alcohol-free and dealcoholised wines that are becoming popular despite being costlier. In dealcoholised wines, alcohol is removed from traditionally fermented wines to under 0.5% alcohol by volume (ABV).

The winery is also using technology and AI to ward off any looming crisis. Martin Linser, head of Competence Center for Viticulture 4.0, an experimental platform to help small and medium-sized wine estates handle climate change, says heat severely affects the grapes in the winery, which is located in a warm region and has steep slopes. It has installed viti-photovoltaic systems that not only produce electricity but also protects grape from extreme heat as well as hail, heavy rains and frost.

While drones are being used for cost-effective spraying of pesticides on steep slopes, autonomous tractors and machines, equipped with advanced sensors and self-steering systems, are making up for a limited workforce.

Harsh summers are prompting wineries to go for early harvests as prolonged exposure to heat could make the grapes sweeter and increase the alcohol content.

The changing weather patterns are affecting the production of wines. Riesling, for instance, which requires a long cool autumn is getting harvested earlier than usual because of late-spring frost. So Germany is working on new hybrids and fungus-resistant grape varieties.

FUTURE-PROOFING VINEYARDS

"Future vineyards will move from reactive farming to predictive farming—where sensors measure, AI interprets and the grower acts before the problem becomes visible," says Manjunath VG, vice-president of viticulture at Grover Zampa Vineyards.

India, though nascent in the wine world, is confident of future-proofing the vineyards as they have embraced technology right from the start. Dogridge, a grapevine rootstock that has high tolerance to drought, is now used in more than 90% of grape acreage, contributing to yield improvements and reduced water requirements, says Manjunath.

"The next major leap will be AI-driven decision support which can convert thousands of data points into a simple question for the grower: What should I do today?" he adds. "The Indian Council of Agricultural Research-National Research Centre for Grapes is already working with AI, IoT sensors and image-based disease detection platforms, and developing geospatial artificial intelligence- and satellite-based precision-viticulture systems."

So, on August 30, the International Cabernet Sauvignon Day, as you raise a glass to that accidental cross that happened in Bordeaux in the 17th century, remember your next exceptional glass could come from anywhere—Argentina, Chile, or as north as Hull in England, or along the Helan mountains in China—weathering climate change with the help of technology.

Garima Verma is a Delhi-based journalist who writes on travel, food and sports

Is Longevity the New Flex?

Wellness is no longer about occasional luxury retreats and holiday spas. It is the constant, granular, unglamorous monitoring of fitness gains and health markers

Ayushi Gupta-Mehra

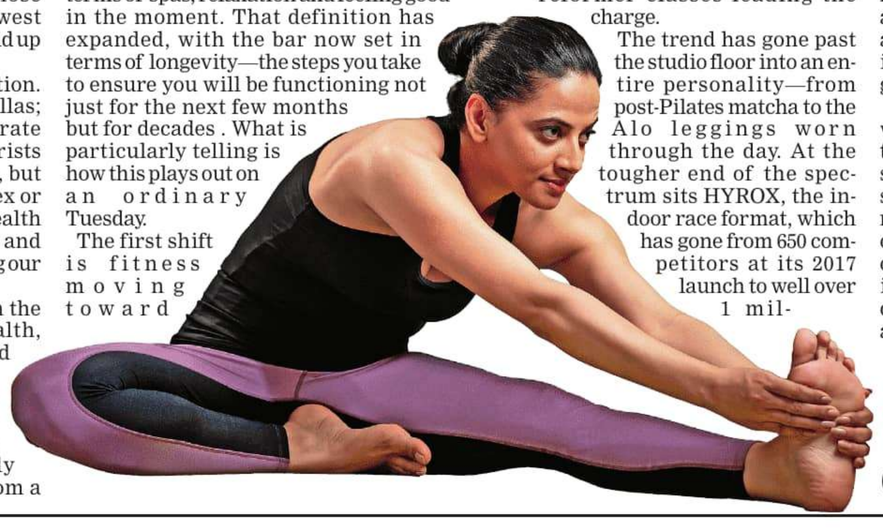
At some point between padel and pickleball on a recent weekend away with friends, the conversation drifted to a place it has never ventured before: Whose resting heart rate had dipped lowest overnight? Whose sleep score had held up despite the wine?

I am still thrown by that conversation. Once we discussed holidays and villas; now we are talking about heart rate variability and recovery scores. Wrists are still held out mid-conversation, but instead of proffering the latest Rolex or Patek release, we are comparing health markers across the different rings and smartwatches permanently adorning our fingers and wrists.

If the old flex was departing from the everyday routine to invest in health, usually at a luxury health and wellness clinic in the Austrian or Swiss Alps, the new flex is more granular and considerably less photogenic—the daily, undramatic evidence that you are consciously managing your own trajectory, from a self-imposed 10 pm bedtime to knowing your resting heart rate at any given point in the day.

It is a momentous shift in how we understand wellness—once thought of in terms of spas, relaxation and feeling good in the moment. That definition has expanded, with the bar now set in terms of longevity—the steps you take to ensure you will be functioning not just for the next few months but for decades . What is particularly telling is how this plays out on an ordinary Tuesday.

The first shift is fitness moving toward performance-driven goals—from how the body looks to what it can do. Pilates was the most-booked workout globally on the ClassPass app for the third year running, with bookings up 66% year-on-year and reformer classes leading the charge.



The trend has gone past the studio floor into an entire personality—from post-Pilates matcha to the Alo leggings worn through the day. At the tougher end of the spectrum sits HYROX, the indoor race format, which has gone from 650 competitors at its 2017 launch to well over 1 million active participants in the 2025-26 season. Pilates promises posture, mobility and longevity of movement, HYROX offers a finish time to chase and beat. Both trade in measurable progress one can track.

The second shift is wellness turning inward, towards the nervous system, since a fight-or-flight mode that is switched on for too long does damage that no number of kilometres logged can offset. Breathwork and sound baths — once dismissed as fringe, new-age indulgences—are showing up in corporate boardrooms and performing arts centres. Both ask nothing more of you than lying still and breathing. After decades of wellness measured in reps and steps, the latest frontier is how quickly your system can be talked down.

LIFE'S SCORECARD

Wearable technology is quietly stitching this wellness and longevity framework together, turning fitness gains and nervous-system resets into a number you can monitor daily. Smartwatches have been central to this, offering key health markers in an instant—from a cardio fitness score estimating how efficiently the heart is working, to on-demand ECG readings exportable as a proper report for a doctor, to guided mindfulness sessions one tap from the watch face. Given that the install base runs into hundreds of millions of wrists, this quietly enrols a large audience into longevity tracking by default even if the watch was bought for unrelated reasons.

In this newly quantified world, wellness destinations earn their draw through recalibration rather than leisure, with privacy and quiet becoming bigger luxury signals than the destination itself. Longevity sanctuaries now use advanced diagnostics to map what a body needs, building a bespoke recovery plan involving cryotherapy, IV drips formulated to individual bloodwork and elemental diets.

What stayed with me long after I'd checked out of a longevity retreat wasn't any single treatment—it was how minute the actual takeaways were. Three minutes in a cryochamber at -110°C was a masterclass in endurance and in discovering what my body could tolerate. A postural scan revealed imbalances that years of gym sessions had never corrected. Gut health, treated as foundation rather than afterthought, was exactly the unglamorous daily maintenance this broader shift has been circling.

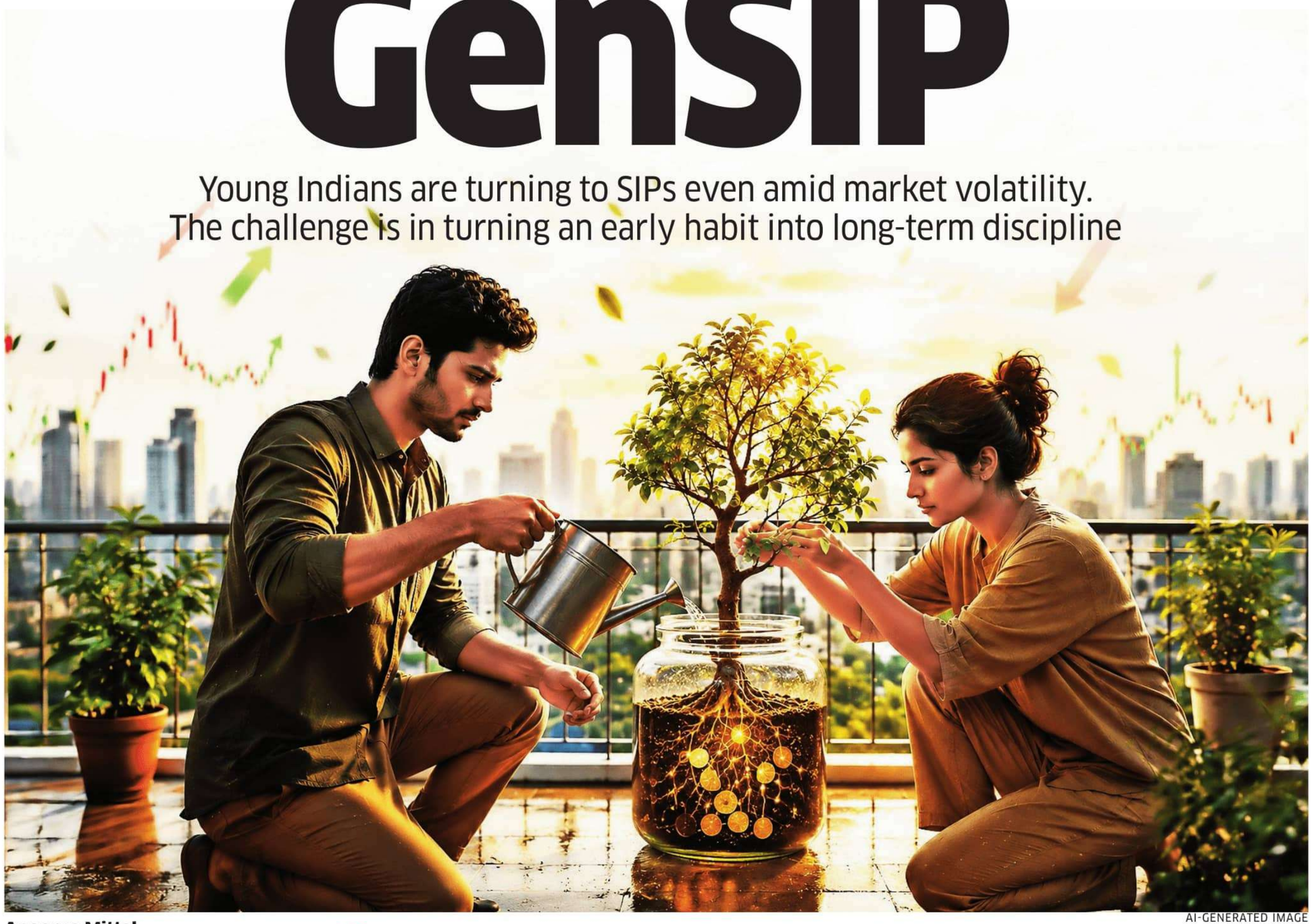
When data is free and daily habits are DIY, the everyday longevity flex is fairly unglamorous, which is perversely why it works as the new status symbol. Sleep consistency matters more than sleep hours—going to bed early every night is a bigger green flag than clocking eight hours erratically. The discipline is doing it on an ordinary Tuesday, long after anyone's watching. You can book the retreat and strap on the wearable, but no one can buy you the willpower to show up for an early morning workout or stick to the 10:30 pm lights out. That's what makes consistency—unglamorous and unphotographable—the one flex still genuinely hard to fake.

The writer is an economist and founder of The Foodie Diaries (Views are personal)

In this newly quantified world, longevity sanctuaries use advanced diagnostics to map what a body needs, building a bespoke recovery plan involving cryotherapy and IV drips formulated to individual bloodwork

GenSIP

Young Indians are turning to SIPs even amid market volatility. The challenge is in turning an early habit into long-term discipline



AI-GENERATED IMAGE

SIP LINE

- SIPs are becoming the default entry point for investment for younger Indians
- Teenagers and young adults are starting SIPs long before they have substantial disposable income
- Parents are driving the rise in SIPs among minors—to build a corpus for future expenses, especially education
- Young investors start with modest daily or monthly amounts
- Social media is playing a growing role in financial discovery
- New age fintech is making access easier
- Early exposure to crypto and F&O is pushing some to SIPs as a comparatively disciplined and long-term way to invest

Apoorva Mittal

Like many her age, Srushti I's first brush with investing was through crypto in 2020 when she was just 15. Back then, the asset class was at the peak of market hype. Her father had introduced her to the idea of investing, but over time she began following market trends and discussing investments with friends and peers.

By 18, systematic investment plans (SIPs) had entered her portfolio. "It is hard to save money, so it is better to invest it," she says. Today, the 21-year-old content writer and strategist in Bengaluru invests about 10% of her income. Unlike the stereotype of young investors constantly tracking the market, Srushti rarely checks her portfolio. "It stresses me out," she says. "I just let it be there for the long term."

Srushti's move into SIPs is part of a broader shift. For a generation exposed early to crypto, trading and financial content on social media, SIPs are emerging as a more disciplined investing avenue.

The trend of investing earlier is visible in data from mutual fund registrar and transfer agent CAMS. The live SIP count among investors under 20 years nearly doubled in FY26, rising 92% year-on-year to 2.9 lakh, while that of 20-30-year-olds grew 15% to 85.5 lakh. SIP gross sales of these age groups rose 19% and 36%, respectively. The surge of under-20s is on a small base.

The momentum among the youngest cohort has continued into 2026. Between January and June this year, live SIPs among under-20s rose 20.9% to 3.15 lakh. Among 20-30-year-olds, live SIPs stood at 84.8 lakh in June, 2.6% higher than in January, though marginally below the March-end level. Over the same period, monthly SIP gross sales rose 9% for under-20s, from ₹306 crore to ₹334 crore, and 4.1% for 20-30-year-olds, from ₹1,811 crore to ₹1,885 crore.

Crucially, the behaviour is still fragile. Many young investors begin with small, automated contributions, only to stop when markets turn volatile or returns disappoint.

> **For our parents, the default was a fixed deposit or a recurring deposit; for investors in their 20s now, the default is a SIP. The habit forms with the first salary"**
> **HARSH JAIN**
> cofounder, Groww

> **Parents are starting SIPs in the name of their children, minors, so that they have some sort of a safeguard in the future for their education"**
> **EELA DUBEY**
> cofounder, EduFund

PENNY WISE

For young adults, the entry point to investing can be remarkably small. In Ghaziabad, Khwaish Mittal was 20 when he began putting ₹21 a day into silver and gold from his pocket money while finishing his undergraduate degree in business administration. Drawn by short-form content nudging him to save and easy access through fintech investing apps, Mittal began researching "what is safe" to invest in.

Now 24 and studying law, Mittal invests in mutual funds through Groww and runs separate recurring investments in gold and silver through PhonePe and Paytm. He has since increased his daily investment in metals from ₹21 to ₹45. "I will keep doing it, and I won't check it," he says. "I withdraw it when I need it—for a gym supplement or if I want to go on a trip with friends. I don't want to ask my parents for extra pocket money."

Mrin Agarwal, CEO of Finsafe India, a finance education company, says one factor behind the shift towards SIPs could be the experience young investors have had with more speculative forms of investing. "Over the last few years, there was a very high interest from the younger generations in doing futures and options and daily trading," she says. With regulatory studies showing that a large majority of individual derivatives traders lose money, "you're also seeing those investors turning to SIPs", she adds.

Fintech platforms are seeing other signs of SIPs getting embedded in the saving patterns of younger investors. On Groww, investors under 25 years hold roughly two SIPs on average, while those above 25 typically run three-four. Flexi-cap funds carry the highest portfolio weightage among under-25 investors and rank among the largest allocations across other age cohorts.

Gold and silver SIPs have also risen sharply on the platform in FY26, led by investors under 25 years, suggesting that younger investors are increasingly using the SIP route to diversify across asset classes.

"For our parents, the default was a fixed deposit or a recurring deposit; for investors in their 20s, the default is a SIP," says Harsh Jain, cofounder and COO of Groww. "The habit forms with the first salary." Jain says the higher adoption of step-up SIPs among investors under 25 years indicates that the behaviour goes beyond a single market cycle and reflects a broader shift in household savings habits.

AWARENESS CURRENCY

Prabin Agarwal, a mutual fund distributor based in Siliguri, says he has changed his marketing strategy in the past couple of years to reach the younger generation. Earlier, he targeted the youth through Facebook; now he is creating short-form educational content for Instagram. "The youth is looking for short-form content with some humour. They are not averse to knowledge. They just don't want it to be boring. Later, when they become curious, they may move on to long-form content," he says.

Another reason for the growing number of SIPs by the under-20 cohort could be the rising cost of education which is pushing parents to start SIPs for their kids.

Eela Dubey, cofounder of EduFund, a higher studies funding platform that helps parents with financial planning for children, and mutual fund distributor Vittam, says education inflation rate is 10% and people are becoming more aware that their disposable income has to go into asset classes that compound their investment.

"In today's day and age, when young kids spend ₹300 for just a cup of coffee, parents and young adults are probably waking up to the reality that previous asset classes are not suitable in all circumstances. For the young, it is the sheer fact of being alive at a different time than their parents' that is opening their eyes to investing in mutual funds and SIPs," says Dubey.

She says 25-30% of her customer base has consistently comprised of first-time investors who are investing on behalf of their children: "They are starting SIPs in the name of their children, minors, so that they have some sort of a safeguard in the future for their education."

> **SIPs that are eventually cancelled tend to have a life of two-three years—far shorter than the long investment horizons associated with equity investing. This can only be solved by educating investors on the right way and by having more accredited advisers in the ecosystem"**
> **NEELESH VERMA**
> product head, mutual funds, Zerodha

Mumbai-based chartered accountant Richa Khanna began a SIP for her son three years ago, when he was 13, using the money he received on birthdays and festivals. "We have certain goals for his higher education," she says. "It is better that the money does not stay idle and is allocated appropriately to a fund."

Pune-based engineer Vishwesh Kulkarni started a SIP of ₹10,000 for his daughter when she was four months old in 2020—although not in her name—and has since increased the amount to ₹40,000 across five SIPs spanning midcap and thematic funds with global exposure.

MARKET TEST

The growing adoption of SIPs among younger investors is being tested by a volatile market and relatively muted returns over the past couple of years. The industry-wide SIP stoppage ratio touched 91.23% in June before easing to 81.87% in July, indicating that the number of SIPs being discontinued or completing their tenure remained high relative to new registrations.

Neelesh Verma, Zerodha's product head for mutual funds, says SIPs that are eventually cancelled tend to have an average life of only two-three years—far shorter than the long investment horizons typically associated with equity investing. "This is something that can only be solved by educating investors on the right way and having more accredited advisers in the ecosystem," he says. At Zerodha, where 25-33-year-olds form a dominant customer cohort, about half the mutual fund customers manually make their monthly SIP payments.

"The markets are unpredictable. You don't know what will happen. Obviously something that has had a boom will have a down cycle also," says Verma.

The big question now is whether the SIP habit among the young can outlast the market's idiosyncrasies.

apoorva.mittal1@timesofindia.com

YOUNG INVESTORS & SIPs

SIP REGISTRATION COUNT*

	EQUITY	DEBT	CASH	OTHERS	TOTAL
Jan '26	28,016	283	128	7,585	36,012
	612,149	7,466	4,449	239,503	863,567
Feb '26	25,196	184	264	5,584	31,228
	574,113	6,943	6,089	189,928	777,073
Mar '26	21,735	167	346	4,237	26,485
	477,288	6,055	7,454	138,491	629,288
Apr '26	22,040	188	654	3,619	26,501
	441,830	5,638	13,118	108,418	569,004
May '26	23,200	184	749	3,862	27,995
	479,869	5,654	12,101	120,852	618,476
June '26	25,960	188	1,150	3,604	30,902
	478,531	5,690	13,852	108,347	606,420

SIP GROSS SALES (in ₹ cr)

	EQUITY	DEBT	CASH	OTHERS	TOTAL
Jan '26	264	10	5	27	306
	1,586	17	7	201	1,811
Feb '26	254	10	5	28	297
	1,541	17	7	196	1,761
Mar '26	273	9	5	30	318
	1,650	58	8	214	1,930
Apr '26	276	9	7	30	322
	1,600	18	9	202	1,828
May '26	274	11	7	30	321
	1,597	19	9	204	1,828
June '26	286	11	7	30	334
	1,647	20	10	208	1,885

Between January and June 2026, live SIPs among under-20s rose 20.9% to 3.15 lakh. Among 20-30-year-olds, live SIPs stood at 84.8 lakh in June, 2.6% higher than in January, though marginally below the March-end level

<20 years | 20-30 years

*Includes SIPs that just got registered as well as those where the first transaction got triggered

SOURCE: CAMS

'AI Introduces a New Set of Problems'

It has been just a couple of months since **Toby Weiss** took over as the CEO of enterprise cybersecurity software company Securonix, headquartered in Texas. He has assumed the role at a time when AI is transforming the threat landscape, with autonomous agents escaping a sandbox during an OpenAI safety evaluation and compromising parts of developer platform Hugging Face's production infrastructure. It demonstrated the sheer randomness of cybersecurity challenges due to AI. Weiss, who was in India recently, spoke to **Nirmal John** about AI's impact, human accountability, India as a vital engineering talent hub and more. Edited excerpts:

Will the deployment of AI in various use cases lead to more consolidation in the fragmented technology landscape that is cybersecurity?

Just yesterday I was talking to the employees about this. In 2009, there were hundreds of security vendors and the discussion was how it was going to consolidate. The consensus was that this is going to consolidate like crazy and there's going to be five major players because no one wants to deal with all these vendors. Fast forward now. I just went to the Black Hat conference in Las Vegas. It looks exactly the same. There are just as many vendors, except every booth said the same thing. They all said AI security and some variation of it. I really felt an enormous empathy for a customer who was walking around.

Will AI simplify? I don't think so. This is a new technology that is moving faster than anything we have seen. Enterprises are adopting it rapidly. Security departments want to naturally say, hold on, let us get our hands around it. But the business value is too big for enterprises to slow down [on AI adoption] right now.

Now not only is AI a new technology, it is a new technology that is very good at finding security vulnerabilities. The stories of last month [the Hugging Face incident] have got everyone terrified.

What I saw at Black Hat is that you now have a ton of new companies saying how we can secure AI. You have existing vendors saying let us expand and make our products more AI.

AI introduces a new set of problems. So, I honestly don't think it's going to change the story in the short term in terms of the fragmented nature of cybersecurity.

It is fascinating what happened around Hugging Face and OpenAI. Are we putting too much trust without truly understanding these systems?

I'm from the Bay Area. You are on the street for not more than 30 seconds and you see Waymos [self-driving cars] whizzing by. It wasn't really that long ago that people were very scared. The talk in my neighbourhood was, would you go in one? Do you trust one? But when I get in an Uber, I really don't know what's going on in that person's brain. In fact, we don't even come close to understanding how the human brain works. And, yet, it's sort of safer for us and we trust it. We do know how AI works. We might not be able to understand in our heads the millions of weights and the model and the particular decision it's making at that moment in time. I think it's really not whether we can trust it or not. It's about whether it is the better way. In cybersecurity there's also a reality that you almost have no choice. The bad guys are going to be using it, so if you are an enterprise, you can't just say, well, I don't trust it. You have to implement it.

How has the incident changed the conversation around cybersecurity and AI in the Valley?

I think what's probably changed in the last month or two is the conversation about how much regulation we should have. Do we need an industry consortium like in some aspects of finance where companies get together and self-regulate before the government does? There's another group that says we need to slow things down. So I think the discussion has really been about how do we govern it.

The fact that it was a Chinese model that helped Hugging Face makes it even more interesting from both an open-source and geopolitical point of view

The way the technology is built, the same AI won't give you the same answer each time. So from our perspective, it's incredibly important to have many models. To have choice. You are going to need other tools in the toolbox.

> "Not only is AI a new technology, it is also very good at finding security vulnerabilities. The stories of last month [Hugging Face incident] have got everyone terrified"

What's your vision for Securonix in the middle of this flux?

I think we are at an inflection point now where the number of events is going to skyrocket. The organisations, of course, are going to increase their spending, but they can't handle this problem manually. Our vision is to help our customers be prepared for security in the age of AI.

India is now a decently sized market for cybersecurity products and is a major engineering talent pool. How is the market for you?

We do extremely well in the India market. From a sales perspective, close to 15% of the revenue comes from India. I think part of it is also because we have a big local presence. The founders of our company were very eager to invest early in India from an R&D perspective. I'm probably more excited about the market opportunity than the talent. The talent's already there and it's great.

What is the percentage of business in India that's coming from government versus private enterprises?

Oh, good question. It's mainly private.

nirmal.john1@timesofindia.com

Elevator, That Space Where You Leave All That Elevated Discussion Behind

Forget that breeding ground of corporate clichés that is the boardroom – the real thoughts after any office brainstorming session are aired in the other closed-door 'after meeting' that's going up or down

READING THE ROOM

PAPA CJ

The title of this column might lead you to believe I'm talking about technology fitted into office buildings. But the last time I asked Siri to 'Call dad,' it replied, 'Which dad would you like me to call?'

So first, I'm not qualified to talk about technology. And second, I'm incredibly grateful that my mother was not with me at the time. What I'm talking about is the intelligence in the room. Not the amount present, but the amount that finds its way into the conversation.

You see, every organisation has two meetings. The scheduled meeting takes place in the boardroom. The honest one usually starts in the elevator afterwards.

Inside the boardroom, the meeting ends exactly as meetings have ended since PowerPoint was invented. 'Great discussion, everyone.'

Laptops snap shut with the urgency of people escaping a small fire. Someone spends longer winding up their laptop charger than they spent contributing to the meeting. Another suddenly remembers they have a 'hard stop', which is corporate terminology for 'I have suffered enough.'

Then everyone walks out. The elevator doors close. And almost on cue the honest meeting starts when somebody says, 'So what did you really think?'

It's one of the fastest personality transformations you'll ever witness. The executive who spent 2 hours nodding thoughtfully suddenly develops concerns. The person who volunteered to 'take ownership' begins explaining why this technically belongs to another department. And the person who said, 'Absolutely, let's do it,' reveals that by 'absolutely' they meant 'under no circumstances whatsoever.'

YOU FUDGED THOSE QUARTERLY NUMBERS, DIDN'T YOU?

Corporate life demands extraordinary acting ability. I've been a professional performer for over 20 years, and I've seen acting in boardrooms that would put Broadway to shame. If there were Oscars for office behaviour, the competition would be fierce.

Best Performance While Completely Disagreeing. Outstanding Achievement in Thoughtful Nodding. Best Supporting Smile. Best Original Excuse for Leaving Early. Best Visual Effects for Pretending to Take Notes While Actually Answering WhatsApp. And a Lifetime Achievement Award for Looking Fascinated During Slide 83.

Then there's the executive who begins every contribution with, 'Just to play devil's advocate...' Moments later, the devil mysteriously disappears, leaving only the advocate. I've always felt sorry for the devil. He gets blamed for an astonishing number of opinions that clearly belong to other people, and yet never seems to get invited to the meeting himself.

It's amazing how much organisational clarity can fit inside an elevator. I've stopped judging meetings by what gets said inside the room

The most impressive performer of all, however, is the person who says absolutely nothing for 2 hours, and then, somewhere between the boardroom door and the parking lot, delivers the single-most insightful observation of the entire afternoon. It's extraordinary. Apparently, wisdom isn't allowed in the room. It has to wait outside until it's kryptonite, the projector, has been switched off.

I've seen versions of that moment all over the world. Different industries. Different cultures. Different languages. Exactly the same elevator.

The strange thing is that I don't think people are being dishonest in meetings. They're being careful. Nobody wants to ask the question that makes 20 pairs of eyes swivel instinctively towards the CEO before deciding whether it's safe to answer. It's democracy, but with one voter.

I've lost count of how many times I've heard the same corridor conversations all over the world. Only the accents change. 'He'd already decided before we walked in.' 'I still don't know what we actually agreed.' 'Wait, are we doing that?' 'I thought you were going to say something.' 'I thought YOU were going to say something.' Or my favourite, 'That'll never get through finance.'

It's amazing how much organisational clarity can fit inside an elevator. That's why I've stopped judging meetings by what gets said inside the room. I'm far more interested in what gets said on the way out. Because if the most useful conversation only begins after the meeting has ended, perhaps the smartest room in the building was never the boardroom in the first place. It was always the elevator.

FILM FATALE

ANNA MM VETTICAD

Dolly Parton Wasn't Just Travelin' Thru

Her remarkable legacy lies not just in her music, but in her empathy, progressive politics and extraordinary philanthropy

I'm out here on my journey, trying to make the most of it
I'm a puzzle, I must figure out where all my pieces fit.
—Travelin' Thru, Dolly Parton

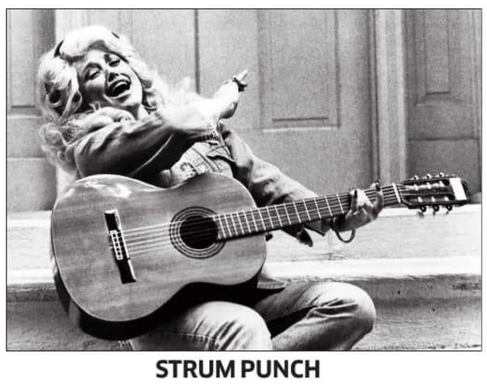
As I read these lyrics in the week of Parton's passing, it feels like they were written for her obituary. Not only do they perfectly represent life in general — hers and ours — but they're also an example of her genius and empathy.

Parton wrote and sang 'Travelin' Thru' for the 2005 film Transamerica, in which Felicity Huffman played a transgender woman on a road trip with her son. Through lines that could apply to just about anyone, she drove home the truth that those we perceive as The Other are no different from each of us.

Country music does not have a mass following in India. So if you want a Beginner's Guide to Dolly, I suggest starting with 'Jolene,' 'I Will Always Love You,' 'Coat of Many Colors,' the feminist anthem '9 to 5' — from the pathbreaking blockbuster of the same name in which she also starred with Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin — 'Why'd You Come In Here Lookin' Like That' and 'Islands In the Stream,' her duet with Kenny Rogers.

The Tennessee-born Parton is one of the best-selling musicians of all time, a much-feted actor, producer, and multi-millionaire businessperson. I loved her music. But more importantly, I was inspired by her pizzazz, philanthropy, progressive views, and the stories behind some of her songs.

Parton was born into poverty, and never forgot her roots. 'Coat of Many Colors,' for instance, was a poignant ode to her mother sewing a multi-coloured coat for her from 'a box of rags that someone gave us'. In the 1990s, her Dollywood Foundation launched an education initiative called The Imagination Library,



STRUM PUNCH

'because my father could not read and write and I saw how crippling that could be'. Every child enrolled in the programme is gifted a book every month until they turn 5. It started in her home county in of Sevier County, Tennessee, expanded US-wide, and now operates in some other countries too.

Parton opposed homophobia and publicly supported marriage equality long before it was cool to do so, saying with characteristic humour in a 2014 interview, 'I think gay couples should be allowed to marry. They should suffer just like us heterosexuals.'

One of my favourite Dolly Parton stories is the one about Elvis Presley in the 1970s showing interest in recording her superhit, 'I Will Always Love You'. Forbes notes that the King of Rock 'N' Roll wanted half the publishing rights, which would have guaranteed him a 50% cut of royalties for as long as he owned the rights. Parton said no.

She told the magazine W in 2021, 'I wanted to hear Elvis sing it, and it broke my heart — I cried all night. But I had to keep that copyright in my pocket. You have to take care of your business! Everybody's going to use you if they can.' The decision proved tremendously profitable since Whitney Houston's cover of the song in the 1992 film Bodyguard became an international rage, making millions for the original copyright owner.

But Parton wore her brilliance lightly, wrapping it in a distinctive package of giant blonde wigs, talons for fingernails, rhinestone-studded flashy outfits, and overtly heavy makeup.

Gifted artists sometimes burden us with the dilemma of having to figure out whether the only way to love their work is to separate the art from the artist. Parton leaves us with no such burden. Her artistic output was supremely entertaining and routinely — often unobtrusively — political. But her politics was not confined to her art. She walked the talk through her charitable works and advocacy for the marginalised, leaving no room for doubt that in her case, the art *was* the artist.

How to Turn the Light Off and Keep It On

For country or locality, we all want to crack a puzzle: letting the right ones in, and keeping the wrong ones out

RED HERRING

INDRAJIT HAZRA

Nice places attract people. They just do. But not all people in these nice places may take to the people who find 'their' place attractive enough to come visiting, or to settle down in. That's not just true of Smiths in Croydon and Patels in Richmond, scrunching up their noses at the thought of more Patels from Madhapar moving to London. Wannabe asset-strippers like Don Trump are also attracted by resourceful places like Greenland and Canada to want to Venezualise them as their own.

Being against outsiders of the 'wrong type' and in support of the 'right type' coming into your neighbourhood may not sound very liberal or textbook 'atithidevo bhava'. But then, which SoBo resident would like all-nighter jaagran-enthusiastic neighbours? Which inhabitants of Oud-Zuid (Old South), one of Amsterdam's poshest districts, would take to burqawalis pram-pushing in the local park? Both Venetians in Venice and Jarawas in the Andamans are understandably xenophobic about tourists descending on them like loud ebola.

In 2001, I was on a secondment with The Times, London, for 3 months. On the morning of September 11, I was attending an editorial meeting where the big news of the day being discussed was the growing influx of immigrants from places like Iraq, Afghanistan, Kurdish Türkiye, and Iran into Britain via the refugee camp at Sangatte in the northern coast of France.

Over that year, the number of refugees had swelled significantly to more than 1,000 — Sangatte was designed to temporarily house 200-500 people. Things reached a flashpoint when hundreds tried to break into the Eurotunnel to illegally move into the 'nice' final destination: Britain. My input was articulating the need to solve the puzzle: How do you turn off the light of a lighthouse for people you don't want to come to your coast, while ensuring that the people who you *do* want to come, come in and don't get dashed against the rocks?

It's another matter that by London lunchtime, Sangatte was displaced by a bigger news development I was watching real-time taking place across the pond in New York. But 25 years later, the 'lighthouse problem' not just remains, but has grown into both mainstream geopolitical and dinner conversation.

A 'nice' place, for people trying to either move there or acquire it as property is, of course, relative. For the dollar millionaire 'stuck' in his luxury condo in waterlogged, AQI-ravished Jor Bagh, moving to California's Pacific Palisades has the same fundamental reasoning behind it as a Rohingya refugee's from Myanmar or a Bangladeshi's to move to India: a better life.

Some places have started deliberately making themselves unattractive, or even, in Trump's highly effective description, 'shitholes'

COME HITHER LOOKS: NEW YORK, 2023 (LEFT); GURGAON, 2026

Which is why it's my firm belief that some places have started deliberately making themselves unattractive, or even, in Trump's highly effective description, 'shitholes'. That has to be the only explanation why, despite engines of the Indian economy purring like a tom cat on E20, we are fed visuals of waterlogged Gurgaon, gridlocked Bangalore, lunar stretches in Mumbai... Even NYC has taken to this strategy, of late, showcasing waterlogged streets after a heavy downpour.

It's also why cities like Kolkata have, for decades, been happy to bask in its reputation as a crumbling boondock village pretending to be a city. (The flip reasoning may have been why Thomas and William Daniell created those iconic paintings and sketches of bucolic late 18th c. Bengal: to draw in the British seeker of a better life to an Orientalist, tropical Silicon Valley-Ko Samui.)

India and 'nice' parts of India have also taken to the cunning strategy of coming across as an increasingly *visibly* hard place to live in. That way, unwanted folks toying with the idea of moving here will junk such plans. Current residents would also be spared the influx of unwelcome outsiders. At the same time, shiny things like GDP, PR, and ultra-real estate prices will hopefully get the 'right sort' to come to a place near you, adding (market and prestige) value to your neighbourhood.

Who said you can't turn the light off to keep 'those ones' out, while keeping the light on for those you'd be delighted to have Sunday brunches at the club with?

indrajit.hazra@timesofindia.com

LET'S TALK ABOUT...

Return of The Bird Mail

(Humming) Kabootar ja ja ja...

Singing again, I see. Now what has you breaking into this ditty?
It's the return of the carrier pigeon, albeit for a digital world.

Can you please speak English? What's going on?
Apparently, texting is done, bro. So a new app, Roost, lets you send messages by virtual birds at their actual flying speeds!

What? Who needs that?
(Shrugs) Well, someone does. Logan Mendelsohn, a senior product manager at Ticketmaster, developed the social app Roost Social as a silly side project. His friends enjoyed the concept so much that they convinced him to put it on the App Store in April. By August, it has hit almost half a million users.

But what does it do?
It is what I said: sending messages via birds. These are virtual birds, of course. But it's not an animated bird mail—the bird flies across a real map at its real-life flying speed to reach the receiver's location. All those who join get a rookery, and you can choose four birds, with the option to collect more later. How fast your mail reaches depends on your bird's flying speed.

Interesting times we live in.
Truly. In fact, while you can send messages to any of your contacts on the app, it has a Pen Pal section to find strangers to write to. You can match with anyone on the app across the world, with matches based on things like age and shared interests. Now the founder is pushing this part of the feature because it's gaining the most traction.
What also gets users hooked is time spent with the birds. You get to train them, and the more you train, the faster they become. There's also a Tamagotchi-like Care feature to groom, bathe and feed them.

I don't know what to say.
Take your time. The message does.
Text: Nupur Amarnath

PHULARI BINA CHUTNEY KAISE BANI?

Mover over oysters, the world is your condiment jar, mixed in culture-commerce

CHAT-G-PATA

SUDHA G TILAK

Chutney is a condiment with many passports. In India, it's as basic as something pounded, ground, or mixed in kitchens, changing its flavour profiles with the seasons and regions. And then it travelled.

In the Caribbean, Indian migrants carried their foodways with them, and chutney became music. Bhojpuri folk traditions met calypso and soca, producing the hybrid 'chutney soca'. Trinidadian singer Drupatee Ramgoonai officially coined the term with her 1987 album Chatnee Soca. But the ball had started rolling way back in 1969 with fellow Trinidadian Sundar Popo, the 'father' of chutney music, coming up with the hit track, 'Kaise Bani', with its stirring chorus, 'Phulari bina chutney kaise bani?' (How can fritters be made without chutney?)

In 2020, Tamil singer-songwriter Sean Roldan released 'Idli Chutney', a playful number on how 'Without idli/ There is no chutney'. This happens to be my earworm these days.

Chutney can become rhythm, song, cultural hybrid and, if Salman Rushdie is allowed into the conversation, a way of describing language. In his 1981 novel, Midnight's Children, Rushdie used 'chutnification' for the mixing and transformation of English with Indian languages.

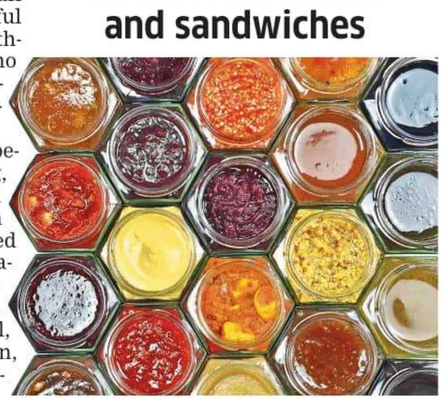
Chutney always enjoyed the status of a market commodity abroad, rather than the homemade and regional varieties that's here in India. Called 'blatjang' in Afrikaans, Cape Town produced its own Mrs HS Ball's Chutney in the 1900s, a sweet mango flavoured one in a city with a sizeable Indian population.

I discovered more during an unscientific, but enjoyable, recent market survey in London. I stopped at supermarket shelves and found delicious jars of mango, red onion, Ploughman's, chilli, caramelised onion, tomato, fig, and honey chutneys. Among the Raj-era versions were Bengal Club, Colonel Skinner's, and Major Grey's.

Sharwood's mango chutney smiled sweetly this summer. I love it that chutney in Britain has escaped the Indian restaurant and sits beside cold meats, sandwiches, poppadums and crackers, and has earned a place on the cheese board.

The British chutney shelf is part of a much older story of Indian flavours travelling West. Sharwood's, for instance, traces its origins to James Allen Sharwood's travels to India in the 19th c and says it introduced Green Label Mango Chutney to Britain in 1889. By 1893, the company had begun working with Vencatachellum Madras Curry Powder, distributing Indian condiments before developing a chutney brand of its own.

Chutney in Britain has escaped the Indian restaurant and sits beside cold meats and sandwiches



LOVIN' SPOONFUL

India's vegetable chutney repertoire is expanding into packaged foods, driven by ecommerce, packaging innovations, and consumers' appetite for both fusion and traditional foods. A Kissan executive shared with me a Nielsen-based estimate that India's existing packaged chutney market is roughly ₹350 cr. About ₹200 cr is Schezwan, followed by tamarind, garlic and mint or pudina.

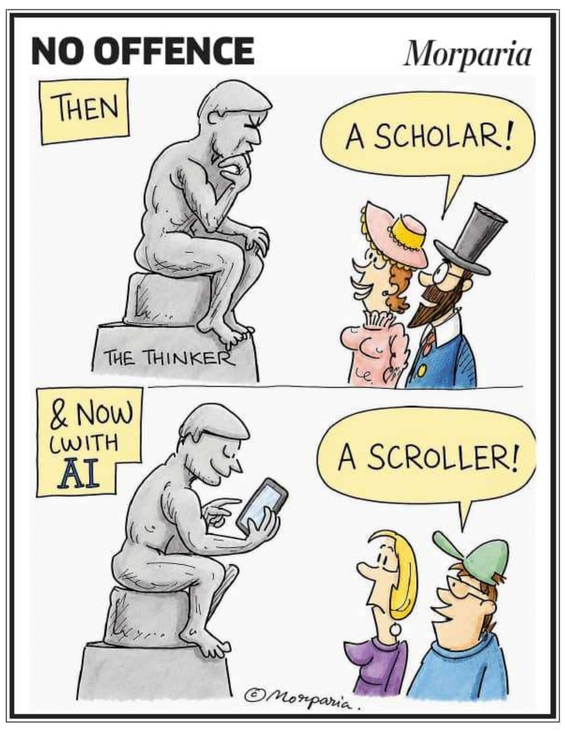
Coconut chutney, despite its ubiquity in South Indian homes, remains tiny as a packaged category, perhaps because of its fresh ingredients and short shelf life, but my South Indian friends swear by it. Chutney is estimated to have roughly 4x as many usage occasions as ketchup, and the packaged market may be capturing only a fraction of what Indians consume.

GlobalData puts the chutneys-and-relishes category, including sweet pickles, at ₹5,586 cr in 2023, after growing at a 10.07% CAGR from 2018 to 2023. Its newer 2024 analysis puts the category at ₹5,902 cr, up 5.65% y-o-y, with a 2019-24 CAGR of 8.99%. Tata Sampann, Dabur, Mother's Recipe, iD and Haldiram's are putting ready-to-eat chutneys into jars, pouches and tubs.

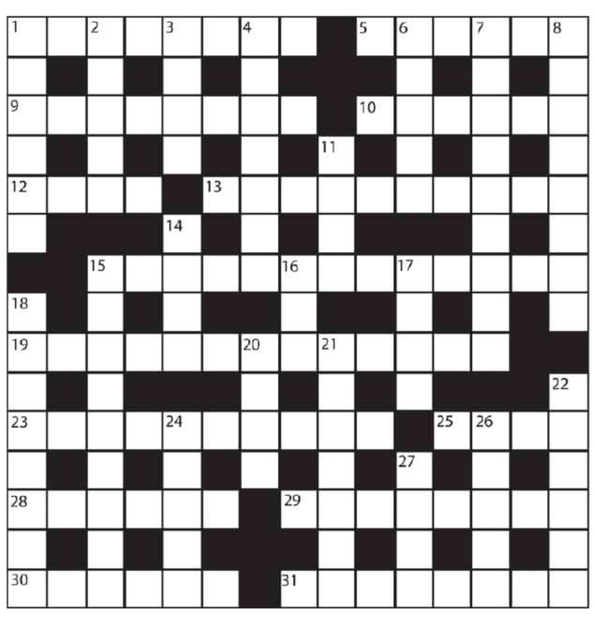
The British supermarket shelf shows what happens when chutney becomes a food category and eventually a flavour habit. India's bottled-chutney boom may be small, but its online fridge or quick commerce isn't. And that's why it is interesting that the next big packaged-food story may not be another imported sauce. It could jolly well be the green, red, brown, sour, hot, sweet and gloriously unruly chutneys that Indians have been making all along.

The writer is author of Chutney Chronicles

NO OFFENCE *Morparia*



ET Sunday Crossword 0183



ACROSS
1 Leave English queen with no space in Wash (8)
5 Doctor retains unlimited cash to raise price unfairly (6)
9 Serial killer in suburbs of Finchley in showy clothes (8)
10 He carries drink across a river (6)
12 Water-carrier moves to and fro in brewery (4)
13 Longed to cover southern journey in sort of suit (10)
15 Tiddly estate incorporates old rides (5-2-6)
19 What those who chose Miliband said, suitably equipped? (4-9)
23 Cook studies this golf course (10)
25 Lover's knot picked up (4)
28 A tax on a radical blockbuster film (6)
29 Twice give up attempt to score at Murrayfield (4,4)
30 Observe article and get angry (6)
31 Mishandle poor illiterate that is ignored (3-5)

DOWN
1 Polish and French regularly strike (6)
2 Singing group mentioned in papers (5)
3 Catch sight of eastern agent (4)
4 Inspire dread? Try fire crackers (7)
6 Prince (Arab) tours Middle East and Spain (5)
7 Immature writer cuts ruined novel (9)
8 Adult in despair managed to find perfect place (8)
11 Banks abandon go slow in capital (4)
14 Fearsome swimmer at back of Balearic island (4)
15 Makes the most of fish and drink (9)
16 Sticky stuff is not all fine (3)
17 German loves keeping dry (4)
18 Have targets unplanned benefits for opposition? (3,5)
20 Type of rock group, unknown to some extent (4)
21 Eternal, timeless, corrupt (7)
22 Pour liquid in it usually (6)
24 14 organised harbour for fish (5)
26 Cream drunk in middle of Peel (5)
27 Small depression in bill (4)

SOLUTION TO No 0183:
ACROSS: 1 Bequeath. **5** Gazump. **9** Flipper. **10** Bearer. **12** Ewer. **13** Pinstriped. **15** Merry-go-rounds. **19** Well appointed. **23** Gastronomy. **25** Beau. **28** Avatar. **29** Drop kick. **30** Seethe. **31** Ill-treat.
DOWN: 1 Buffet. **2** Quire. **3** Espy. **4** Terrify. **6** Ameer. **7** Unripened. **8** Paradise. **11** Oslo. **14** Orca. **15** Milkshake. **16** Goo. **17** Otto. **18** Own goals. **20** Punk. **21** Immoral. **22** Bucket. **24** Roach. **26** Elite. **27** Spit.

©The Daily Mail

War and US Sanctions Take Toll on Iran's Economy

A view of Strait of Hormuz from the beach of Bandar Abbas, Iran

Reuters

Dubai | Cairo: Iranian leaders are acknowledging the economic toll of war with the US, with the supreme leader urging the government to address the hardship and the president saying foreign trade has shrunk by a third due to the American sanctions and blockade.

Yet Tehran signalled no retreat on Saturday, vowing to withstand US pressure, pursue diplomacy and maintain what it said was control over the Strait of Hormuz, the strategic waterway giving Iran leverage through its ability to disrupt global energy markets.

% Iran's foreign trade has shrunk by a third due to US sanctions & blockade

The government said in a statement on state media that addressing economic pressures caused by sanctions and war was a central focus, including curbing inflation, managing markets, creating jobs, directing investment towards domestic production and gradually reducing dependence on the dollar.

The sanctions drive compounds the toll of the war on Iran's economy, where annual inflation hit 66% last month.

President Masoud Pezeshkian told state media that Iranian exports and imports had slumped nearly 35% because of US sanctions and a naval blockade of Iranian ports. But he said Iran was able to sell about 90 million barrels of oil during the short-lived MoU that the US and Iran signed in June, when Washington permitted Iranian oil sales.

Nepal's Flood Damage may Cost up to a Tenth of Economy to Rebuild

Nepal needs $4-5 billion to rebuild, says finance minister Swarnim Wagle

Reuters

Kathmandu: Nepal may need $4 billion to $5 billion to rebuild after this week's devastating floods, Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle said on Saturday, a bill equal to nearly a tenth of the economy.

"The initial estimate is between $4-$5 billion. Just an estimate," Wagle said. "We will require much less than what we needed for the 2015 earthquake. Loss and damage is being assessed."

A glacier collapse on Wednesday unleashed a huge torrent of rock, ice, mud and debris through Himalayan mountain river systems, killing more than 600 people in Nepal and China's Tibet.

The flood levelled towns in the border area, sweeping away bridges and roads and damaging major hydropower stations.

Wagle did not elaborate on why the reconstruction bill was expected to be less than the $9 billion spent after the 2015 magnitude-7.8 quake, Nepal's worst recorded disaster. It killed nearly 9,000 people, destroyed more than half a million homes and caused losses estimated at around a third of Nepal's economy. Wednesday's floods will nevertheless be a major blow to an economy reliant on remittances, tourism and hydropower, damaging power projects that account for over 12% of national generating capacity.

NEARLY 3,000 MISSING

Nearly 3,000 people were still missing on Saturday after flash floods and landslides hit the Nepal-Tibet border. The figures are likely to change.

Nepal's disaster agency increased the total number of people missing on its side of the border to 2,426 on Saturday.

The total number of missing in Tibet is now at 554, with seven people confirmed dead, China's Xinhua news agency reported early on Saturday. Together, the total missing stands at least 2,980.

Nepal's disaster agency on Friday said that 517 foreigners — which could include tourists as well as foreign workers — were still missing. Chinese officials on Friday put the number of foreigners missing at 260.

China's foreign ministry said on Thursday that nearly 100 Chinese nationals were among the missing in Nepal.

Product Planning

▸▸ From Page 1

Uncertainty about what buyers will eventually choose is now being felt in product planning itself, a senior executive at a carmaker said. "You cannot assume that one technology will win across segments. The customer in a city, a highway user and a small-town buyer can have very different requirements."

That is already playing out in the market. Petrol's share fell in recent years, but buyers have not moved en masse to a single alternative. CNG gained ground, diesel remained relevant, EVs are growing and hybrids have found a sizeable niche, said industry executives.

A Delhi-based dealer said customers were increasingly asking about several technologies before making a purchase. "Earlier the conversation was largely about petrol versus diesel. Now customers ask about CNG, hybrid and EVs, depending on their usage. Running cost matters, but so does convenience."

The shift is forcing the industry to make difficult calls. Engine programmes, battery capacity, platforms and supplier investments have to be planned years in advance, even as consumer preferences continue to evolve.

China offers a glimpse of how unpredictable that path can be. Its rapid electrification did not produce an immediate winner in battery-electric vehicles alone. Plug-in hybrids and range-extender vehicles gained momentum as consumers weighed driving range, charging availability and cost.

India is a different market, and the move away from petrol may not follow a straight line, said experts. For now, carmakers are keeping multiple technologies alive and waiting for the market to decide.

Indications of Shorter Tenure

▸▸ From Page 1

On July 23, shortly after Rajiv Kumar took over as the chairman, the board completed an internal review of the bank's arrangements with Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation for mobilisation of deposits in 2017 and 2021. The review concluded that the conduct of certain employees amounted to "business overreach", although it found no conclusive evidence of mala fide intent, personal enrichment or any improper motive.

The board, subsequently, issued warning letters and imposed monetary penalties of ₹1 lakh each on Jagdishan, chief financial officer Srinivasan Vaidyanathan and the group head for retail assets, Arvind Vohra, citing potential divergence from applicable RBI directions.

The action marked the first time HDFC Bank's board had penalised a sitting chief executive.

Sources familiar with the matter said Jagdishan decided against seeking an extension after receiving indications that the RBI was considering a shorter tenure than that sought by the board.

Jagdishan, who joined HDFC Bank in 1996, is due to retire on October 26. He succeeded Aditya Puri as managing director and chief executive in 2020. His departure comes at a time when the long-serving chief financial officer, Vaidyanathan, is also set to complete his term in October.

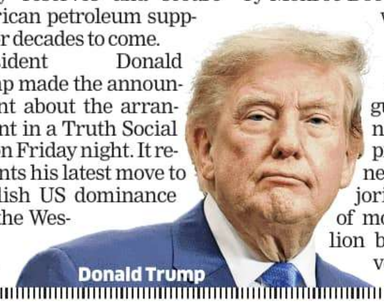
US Set to Take Majority Control of Venezuela's Oil Wealth in Historic Deal

Deal gives the US control over more than 65b barrels of oil reserves

Bloomberg

Washington: The US is set to take majority control over a huge amount of Venezuela's oil wealth in an unprecedented maneuver that officials said would create the world's second-largest private oil company by reserves and secure American petroleum supplies for decades to come.

President Donald Trump made the announcement about the arrangement in a Truth Social post on Friday night. It represents his latest move to establish US dominance over the Western Hemisphere, countering years of inroads by China, as part of his embrace of the 19th-century Monroe Doctrine. Working with Venezuela's interim president, Delcy Rodríguez, a partnership with private business secured majority US control of more than 65 billion barrels of proven reserves in Venezuela, Trump said.



Donald Trump

A US official said that the US will control 55% of the effective output from the joint venture, and will obtain the oil at cost.

The plan represents an unparalleled modern-day intervention into the economy of a South American country Trump once called the 51st US state, harkening back to British control of Iran's oil fields and the division of Iraqi assets among US and European nations a century ago.

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Request for Proposal (RFP) For Field quality assurance & auditing work for project works of Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority

Detailed RFP document is available on the E-Procurement Portal of Government of UP [http://etender.up.nic.in] from 03/09/2026

Interested Bidders are required to apply online on the E-procurement website on or before 17/09/2026, 17:00 hrs (IST). In case of any queries, the Bidders are invited to contact GM (Project), YEIDA.

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Digital Public Infra

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The minister said India's Digital Public Infrastructure such as Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, ONDC and India Stack, has created platforms at population scale.

"The next opportunity is to build higher-value businesses in AI, engineering, analytics, product development, semiconductors and electronics, with India's Global Capability Centres increasingly becoming global innovation hubs," she said.

Sitharaman said GIFT City was emerging as an international financial centre connecting global capital with Indian opportunities. With 1,250 registered entities as of June 2026, it offers opportunities across banking, fund management, reinsurance, aircraft and ship leasing, sustainable finance and other cross-border services, Sitharaman said, inviting global institutions to explore GIFT City as a gateway to India's financial ecosystem.

She said with global supply chains being reconfigured, India offers a compelling combination of a large domestic market and globally competitive manufacturing capabilities.

The focus is moving beyond assembly towards deeper component manufacturing, engineering and advanced technologies, supported by targeted policy measures including production-linked incentives, the minister said.

Sitharaman said India's infrastructure build-out "from dedicated freight corridors and railway modernisation to electrification and high-speed rail" offers opportunities across engineering, technology, materials, specialised equipment and long-term institutional capital.

Familiar Territory

▸▸ From Page 1

"A significant part of this capital is going into the parts consumers rarely see: formulation, repeated testing, clinical validation and R&D."

Queries sent to Beastlife's cofounder Raj Vikram Gupta remained unanswered till press time on Saturday. The large follower base of these creators could be a great marketing platform for their brands, investors said.

"For Underneat, going the influencer route was correct because the category needs a lot of education," said Vinay Singh, founding partner at Fireside Ventures.

"For any category that is niche or emerging, combining a great product with direct community access through the creator is an excellent strategy to build the category while also managing costs."

In most cases, creators have gone and built a product in categories that they have been developing content for. Take Your Food Lab's (YFL's) Keer. After showcasing food recipes, tips and tricks, he started his brand Curaa for cooking appliances because he saw an opportunity in the segment.

Keer's role at Curaa goes beyond marketing. He also looks after research and development (R&D) of the products along with his team. "My experience of working in professional kitchens for two decades, and interaction with millions of people on social media who are a part of the YFL community, helps me understand what the user needs," he said.

HERO PRODUCT

Health influencer Revant Himatsingka, also known as FoodPharmer, started his journey to make Indian consumers aware about the products they are consuming. After he gained popularity in 2023 for his videos decoding the ingredient lists of products, he launched his clean-label protein brand Only What's Needed (OWN) in 2025.

"Protein had the maximum mistrust associated with it. FoodPharmer stands for trust and I thought we could make protein mainstream in India by launching our own brand," Himatsingka said. "About 40% of our users are first-time users. People are buying protein for their parents for the first time; some of these users are over 60 years old."

While the community (of followers) can drive the initial hype, a brand will only pick up if the product is good, said analysts who track the direct-to-consumer (D2C) segment.

Challenges Since 2024

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Over the past two years, the Singapore carrier has recorded around S$1.3 billion ($780 million) in operating losses linked to its stake in the Indian airline, although that figure has improved from S$2.02 billion on its balance sheet as of March 31, 2025. SIA recognised S$945.2 million (approximately $740 million) as its share of Air India's losses for FY2025/26.

The challenges have compounded since SIA committed to Air India in November 2024. The investment was followed by the Ahmedabad aircraft crash, restrictions that forced Indian airlines to avoid Pakistani airspace, and a subsequent surge in fuel prices. Together, these developments have added pressure to an investment that has yet to deliver the returns SIA had anticipated. Defending Temasek's investment in SIA, Teo said, "As we build a resilient and forward-looking portfolio, we support the strategic moves by our portfolio companies that position them for long-term growth and global competitiveness. While such initiatives take time, we believe that they are important for sustaining growth over the long run."

According to its annual report, Temasek's direct exposure to the aviation industry extends well beyond Singapore Airlines (SIA). Its portfolio also includes SATS, where it owns 40%, providing airport ground handling, air cargo and catering services, and ST Engineering, in which it holds 51% and which has a major aerospace business focused on aircraft maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) and engineering.

Industry Seeks Domestic Push

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According to an analysis by the trade think tank GTRI, almost the entire Indian trade in human hair comprised raw and semi-processed hair, while finished products such as human-hair wigs, false beards, eyebrows, eyelashes, etc., were worth only $1.35 million.

The numbers underline a stark imbalance: in a global human-hair extension and wig industry worth $5.2 billion, India supplies the raw material, while China captures much of the value. The Chinese city of Xuchang, in Henan province, is widely regarded as the wig capital of the world.

The Human Hair & Hair Products Manufacturers & Exporters Association of India (HHHPMEAI), which represents 85 of the country's leading human-hair exporters, has repeatedly urged the government to ban raw-hair exports.

The association argues that restricting such exports would secure raw material for Indian processors, while creating more than a million jobs in wig-making and other value-added segments.

In a letter to home minister Amit Shah last year, HHHPMEAI president Benjamin Cherian made another case: even the basic processing of hair—stretching, hackling and sizing—could generate substantial employment for women in Naxalite-affected villages across Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. "Hair processing in Myanmar is cheaper because of the rampant use of child labour. These workers operate for Chinese agents who procure the material," said Sathish Gandhi, director of Chennai-based Allure Hair Products. "The more goli [unprocessed hair] we export, the more employment opportunities we lose at home."

India accounts for 85% of the world's human-hair supply. The raw material feeding the global hair-extension and wig industry comes mainly from two sources in the country.

Chinese hair, however, is considerably thicker than Indian hair, making Indian supplies particularly valuable to Chinese manufacturers, according to exporters.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES | BENGALURU | SUNDAY | 30 AUGUST 2026 | WWW.ECONOMICTIMES.COM

Dear Creators, Stop Using These...

The content cliché factory keeps rolling and has attained a whole new level of virality on social media. **Pratishtha Bagai** has a word of advice for creators: Hit refresh on overused terms

pratishtha.bagai@timesofindia.com

Do you cringe every time you come across a reel that takes you to a "hidden gem"? Or feel annoyed when bombarded with yet another "unpopular opinion"? Welcome to the content clichés of the modern era, where once catchy buzzwords now signal content fatigue and lazy writing. They once helped creators cut through the noise, but now, they just show a disconnect from authenticity.

Manas Raturi, an associate professor at the Jindal Global Law School, says, "The attention economy of social media requires creators to capture the focus of the viewer in the first few seconds." These terms act as hooks, creating a sense of missing out on unique information. "These fears play with the most primal instincts of the person consuming content, and these hooks consciously target them."

But for audiences fatigued by algorithmic bait, these phrases now signal a lack of originality. The way forward? Replace lazy clichés with precise, sensory, story-driven language.

Here's a quick guide:

PIC: SHRIYA PATIL

Mind Your Language

"Language is like currency. The more often a word is spent without earning its keep, the more it depreciates. Initially, these words work because they promise exclusivity or insider knowledge. But repeated exposure breeds scepticism.

"I'd replace vague labels with specific evidence. Instead of saying: 'This is a hidden gem,' say: 'I've lived here for 10 years, and I only discovered this place last week.' Instead of: 'This is an artisanal bakery,' say: 'They mill their own flour every morning.' And instead of: 'An offbeat destination,' say: 'There were more locals than tourists when I visited.'

"Specificity is more persuasive than adjectives. A good hook isn't a flattering label; it's a question, a contradiction or an unexpected fact. Those age much better because they're rooted in information rather than hype."

– SUMANTO CHATTOPADHYAY, creator, The English Nut

VISUALISATION AND DESIGN: ATUL BANDEKAR

Buzzkills

Five more phrases that need a social media sabbatical

POV: Not everything you film is a point of view. Sometimes it's just a regular video

Gamechanger: Not everything can change the game

Obsessed: Good for you. But no!

Must-have: Must you, really? Desire is not an emergency

Maxxing: Skinmaxxing, looksmaxxing, coatmaxxing – no need to optimise everything to the max

Cliché Damage

How tired language can hurt your content

Familiar hooks are easier to skip because audiences know what's coming.

Overselling anything makes audiences question the next recommendation too.

Overuse turns useful words into empty adjectives.

If everyone uses the same vocabulary, it leads to repetitive content.

Predictable content is unlikely to win loyalty.

Hidden Gem

Content Category: Travel
Why it doesn't work: Because one traveller's "hidden gem" is often a local's regular Tuesday lunch spot.

It's now the default label for any destination that isn't already a top-10 tourist hotspot. But in the age of Instagram and Google Maps, truly hidden places are virtually non-existent. The phrase contradicts itself: If a creator is filming the spot, it's no longer hidden.

"For a place to be a hidden gem or offbeat, it should be less accessible, less commercial, and less documented. If not, the term is redundant," said Ajay Raj, 27, a travel creator from Dehradun, who prefers engaging frequent travellers through emotional storytelling.

"I focus on how my experience was rather than the spots I visited."

What to do: If it has 5,000 Google reviews, the gem has been found. Tell us what actually makes the place worth visiting.

Also rans: Offbeat, quaint trails, paradise

Mindset Shift

Content Category: Finance
Why it doesn't work: Because it's so vague, it could mean anything from making a budget to betting on crypto.

"Mindset shift" has become a catch-all for financial advice that doesn't offer concrete steps, implying success is simply a matter of thinking differently. It sounds profound, requires little evidence and flatters audiences into believing they're one mental tweak away from riches. Often, though, it simply masks a lack of substance.

What to do: Not every brainwave is a mindset shift. When it comes to money matters, skip the motivational fog and tell us what to actually do.

Also rans: Financial freedom, passive income, wealth hack

Speakeasy

Content Category: Food & restaurants
Why it doesn't work: Because it has become an aesthetic shorthand rather than a meaningful descriptor.

What began in a specific cultural context is now slapped onto cocktail lounges everywhere. 'Speakeasies' originally described Prohibition-era hidden bars, but today, it's used to build intrigue – regardless of historical relevance or actual secrecy. Creators borrow its nostalgia and exclusivity to make an ordinary spot feel like an insider discovery.

Delhi-based food creator Darshit Singh, 29, admits he too has used such words because they become trends no one wants to miss. The dilemma now is whether even genuinely secretive places can be described this way without audiences calling out the hype. "A lot of such words come from brands that slip into influencers' content without any check from regulator or scepticism from the creators themselves," Singh points out.

What to do: If the "secret" bar has a Google listing, valet parking and an influencer night, perhaps just call it a bar.

Also rans: Farm-to-table, artisanal, organic, signature

Artisanal

Content Category: Fashion & Style
Why it doesn't work: Because the word now covers everything from handwoven textiles to factory-made sneakers.

"Artisanal" once signalled small-batch, handmade quality. Today, it's slapped on to everything from chips to shoes to fast fashion, borrowing the language of craftsmanship to justify a higher price. "Today, when I see labels like 'artisanal' and 'sustainability' slapped on every other product to command a premium, especially by fashion creators and brands, I can tell it is complete hogwash," says Jatin Bhasin, 45, author and creator of Delhi Mirror. "Such words annoy users and feel like a betrayal, especially to those who are passionate about that topic."

What to do: Ask yourself: 'Who made it?' If answer is handmade and small batch, use the word.

Also rans: Curated, sustainable, handcrafted

Unpopular Opinion

Content Category: Commentary
Why it doesn't work: Because it's now a formula and not a genuine expression of dissent.

Most "unpopular opinions" are rarely unpopular. In fact, more often than not, they're mainstream views dressed up as rebellion to spark engagement. It's overused because controversy drives engagement. But audiences are increasingly aware of the tactic, and many now scroll past or mock such posts as performative.

What to do: If everyone agrees with your unpopular opinion, it's not really unpopular.

Also rans: Hot take, let's be real, truth bomb

Mindfulness

Content Category: Wellness
Why it doesn't work: Because they're so overapplied that they no longer convey specific practices or outcomes.

Wellness buzzwords meant to reenergise have become a source of fatigue. We are looking at you, "mindfulness" and "optimise". It's worse now because they're used to sell everything from water bottles to productivity apps. Sumanto Chattopadhyay, actor and creator of The English Nut, a channel dedicated to the nuances of the English language, calls this process "semantic bleaching": The gradual erosion of a word's original meaning through overuse.

What do to: Replace vague labels with specificity, which is more persuasive than adjectives.

Also rans: Holistic, optimise, balance, intentional

'Hello, My Name is Fabulous!' Kim at 70

Kim Cattrall turned 70 on August 21 and, as her iconic character Samantha Jones famously said in *Sex and the City*: "Hello, my name is fabulous!"

More than 28 years after she first sashayed onto our television screens as the confident, dry, man-eating PR boss, few would disagree.

Born in Liverpool in 1956 and raised in Canada, she returned briefly to England as a teenager before moving to New York at 16 to pursue acting. After training at the American Academy of Dramatic Arts, she made her film debut in Otto Preminger's *Rosebud* (1975), followed by TV roles in *Columbo*, *Starsky & Hutch* and *The Incredible Hulk*. She later starred opposite *Jack Lemmon in Tribute* (1980), as well as *Porky's* and *Police Academy*.

Kim Cattrall with Russell Thomas

PICS: GETTY IMAGES, PARAMOUNT PICTURES, INSTAGRAM

STAR IN THE MAKING

Cattrall's big breaks came when she was cast in *Big Trouble in Little China* with Kurt Russell, in 1986, and as a shop doll that comes to life in *Mannequin*, with Andrew McCarthy, the following year.

But in 1988, everything could have changed, as she was booked on the Pan Am 103 flight that was bombed over Lockerbie, killing all 259 people on board, as well as 11 people on the ground, in Dumfries and Galloway.

Kim Cattrall played Samantha Jones in *Sex and the City*

Cattrall later revealed: "I cancelled the day before and booked a later flight so I had time to go to Harrods and buy mum a Christmas present."

FINDING LOVE

Cattrall has spoken candidly about sex throughout her life, including writing *Satisfaction: The Art of the Female Orgasm* with her third husband, the US music engineer Mark Levinson.

In December last year, aged 69, she tied the knot for the fourth time, with 54-year-old sound engineer Russell Thomas, who she met during a 2016 *BBC* radio recording. And Cattrall thinks the key to their continued happiness is not being afraid to put in the hard work. "People feel that it's something that happens and you're lucky," she said. "You meet this person, and the work is just begun. It's not a negative kind of work. This is meaningful for your life."

– Daily Mirror

How to get that all-important great snooze – on a Sunday and every other day of the week

Best of the Rest

Good sleep is one of the most important factors for our health, and not getting enough of it is one of our most common complaints.

When we sleep, tissues are healed and the immune system strengthened. It is also when the brain clears out waste and locks in the day's memories.

And a lack of sleep can contribute to health problems including depression, heart attacks, dementia and obesity. But a third of us experience sleep problems at least once a week. Problems sleeping are particularly common in older adults.

So here we explore the scientific evidence behind sleep and how we can get that perfect, rejuvenating night's shut-eye:

PICS: GETTY IMAGES, AI GENERATED

WHAT THE EXPERTS SAY

A few sleepless nights are usually nothing to worry about, but it can become an issue if a lack of sleep starts to affect your daily life.

Recommended measures to improve sleep include the following:

1. Avoid caffeine or a big meal late in the evening.
2. Try not to use phones, tablets or computers for an hour before bed, because blue light from these screens can make it harder to fall asleep.
3. Talking to someone you trust or writing down your worries can help you manage them.
4. GPs can treat people with insomnia through managing issues such as anxiety, short-term courses of sleeping pills or cognitive behavioural therapy counselling for more severe cases.

HAVE A REGULAR BEDTIME

Going to sleep at the same time each night reduces the risk of a stroke. Emily McGrath, senior cardiac nurse at the British Heart Foundation, said: "Research suggests that disturbed sleep is associated with higher levels of a protein called CRP. This is a sign of inflammation."

A WEEKEND LIE-IN CAN HELP

A 14-year study found those that caught up on sleep at the weekend were a fifth less likely to develop heart disease.

Researchers tracked 91,000 people with wearable devices to monitor their sleep and found that 20,000 were regularly getting less than the recommended seven hours of sleep a night. Those who got at least an extra one hour and 17 minutes sleep over the weekend were 20 per cent less likely to develop conditions such as ischaemic heart disease.

Professor James Leiper, associate medical director at the British Heart Foundation, said: "While a weekend lie-in is no replacement for a regular good night's rest, this large study suggests that it might help reduce risk of heart disease."

HOW MUCH SLEEP DO I NEED?

Experts say that the average amount of sleep needed by adults is seven to nine hours, while children need around nine to 13 hours. Sleeping too much can be a sign you are unwell.

A study covering one million people in six countries showed less than seven hours of sleep a night was linked to a seven per cent greater risk of high blood pressure.

EXERCISE CAN HELP TACKLE INSOMNIA

Research shows that exercising at least twice a week cuts the risk of insomnia. People who do regular workouts are 42 per cent less likely to have difficulty falling asleep and 22 per cent less likely to report insomnia.

Imperial College London reviewed data on 4,339 people from nine European countries over 10 years and found people who kept exercising in the long term were 55 per cent more likely to be good sleepers.

WEIGHTLIFTING AND TAI CHI

One review of 24 clinical trials sought to establish which forms of exercise were best for sleep.

The trials scored the sleep quality of 2,045 people aged 60 after the following forms of exercise: Aerobic (such as cycling, dancing, swimming, brisk walking and hiking), resistance (such as lifting weights, arm curls, wall push-ups and gym machines), balance (such as sideways walking, heel-to-toe walking, one-leg standing) and flexibility (such as gymnastics, yoga, dance and pilates).

Aerobic exercise or a mix of exercises helped tackle insomnia, but not as much as resistance exercise such as heavy lifting. And a separate study published in the *British Medical Journal* found tai chi was just as effective as the treatment of cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT).

WHAT TIME YOU EXERCISE MAKES A DIFFERENCE

Researchers have also looked at the importance of the so-called circadian rhythm and if someone is an 'early bird' or a 'night owl'.

A trial showed exercising at the right time of day for your body boosted a host of heart health measures as well as sleep quality.

The study, published in the journal *Open Heart*, looked at chronotypes of 150 middle-aged participants who were randomly assigned to groups for exercise that either matched their circadian rhythm or did not. Workouts were scheduled between 8 am and 11 am, or 6 pm to 9 pm.

Improvements were greater when exercise time was matched to chronotype — for example, morning people went to the gym before work. This group saw blood pressure cut more and greater improvements for functions such as heart rate, aerobic capacity and sleep quality.

Researchers suspect that exercising at the time best suited to your body works muscle and fat

SLEEP LIKE THIS TO AVOID GOING BLIND

A little-known fact was proven recently — sleeping with your head and neck on a high pillow position increases the risk of glaucoma.

A trial showed that sleeping on stacked pillows alters the neck position to compress the jugular vein and prevent natural drainage of fluid in the eye.

This increases internal eye pressure, which can lead to optic nerve damage and glaucoma — a risk for people aged over 40 and which can lead to blindness if untreated.

– Daily Mirror

WEEKEND POSER

How Do I Know if My Old Book is Worth Something?

By Becky Meloan

To determine the value of an old book, you need look at a specific set of factors. But before that, keep in mind, an old book's market value is exactly what someone will pay for it, so an outrageous price listing online isn't a true data point until the moment of sale.

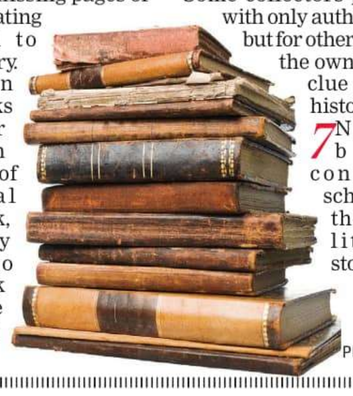
Additionally, there are other measurements of a book's value — historical, personal — which will not always be reflected in prices online.

Evaluating those factors takes someone with a lot of experience, but before talking to an expert, you can perform your own triage by considering these elements.

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

1. When looking at a vintage copy of a book, check for those little brown stains. Check that it's not mold because that really is the enemy of old books.
2. Other problems to watch out for include missing pages or markings indicating a book used to belong to a library. Modern ex-library books are red flags for collectors, in part because of the physical damage from ink, glue and heavy use, and also because a book with no resale value is a book nobody steals off an open shelf.
3. Look for a first-edition designation and a number line — 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10. In the early 1970s, Simon & Schuster didn't print 'First Edition', so its absence, along with the number line, signalled a first printing. The lowest number indicates the print run: 1 for the first, 2 for the second, and so on.
4. Check the front inside flap to see if the price is showing. A price that has been cut out — referred to as 'price-clipped' — can sometimes negatively affect market value for collectors who prefer their copies pristine.
5. Check to see if the author or another famous person has signed one of the book's pages, and note whether it is inscribed to another person. When a signature appears on a separate paper that is either affixed to the book or 'laid in', such as on a bookplate, it can hold less value to some collectors.
6. Also check whether an owner put their name in the book. Some collectors prefer books with only author signatures, but for others, the name of the owner provides a clue to the book's history.
7. Notes in old books contribute to scholarship and therefore keep little-known stories alive.

– The Washington Post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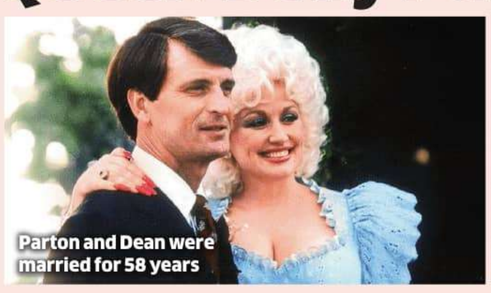
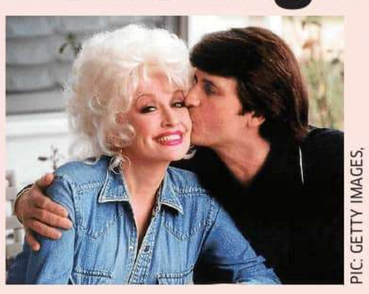
Country Queen Dolly Parton's Legendary Love Story

The singer met 21-year-old Carl Dean outside a laundromat when she was just 18


Parton and Dean were married for 58 years


PIC: GETTY IMAGES,

It is easy to understand why so many people fell in love with country legend Dolly Parton. It was the way she made you feel at the centre of her world, despite her enormous fame.

Physically, Parton was petite. In every other way, she was enormous with charisma to fill a room twice the size.

She remembered your name. She remembered your wife's name. She remembered your children. Perhaps some of that came from never forgetting where she started: One of 12 children, growing up in poverty in the Tennessee mountains.

She was old school, too. Nothing was off limits. She was uproariously funny, filthy and very, very flirty.

ONE GREAT LOVE

But she was no pushover. Once she was pushed a little too hard on the rumours about her relationship with her best friend Judy Ogle. "It doesn't upset me but it upsets and embarrasses Judy and her family," she said sternly.

But this was Dolly Parton and within seconds, the twinkle was back. She left you smitten, of course, but there was only ever one great love of her life. Husband Carl Dean.

The man himself was almost never seen. He seemed to exist somewhere beyond her technicolour world, content to stay firmly out of the spotlight.

And despite the endless rumours about her love life, Parton insisted that Dean was never remotely troubled by them. "Sometimes he sees some story and he'll say, 'I see you're having Burt Reynolds' baby again'," she once said. "He's not jealous. Lord, they had me sleeping with everybody — I'd have never got anything done," Dolly joked: "And the ones I did sleep with, they don't know about."

RIDICULOUSLY ROMANTIC

Her and Dean's love story was the stuff of music legend. They met outside Nashville's Wishy-Washy laundromat when she was just 18. Carl (21) struck up conversation by saying she was going to get sunburn in her revealing outfit. "My first thought was I'm going to marry that girl," Carl once said. "My second was, 'Lord she's good lookin'."

Despite being the subject of red-headed bank clerk Jolene's advances in Parton's famous 1973 song, he quietly lived on their farm, running his paving firm until he retired.

"Come springtime in Tennessee, we have buttercups coming up around the side of the barn and last week he brought me a little mason jar full of them and wrote me a little poem," she said a few years ago.

They marked their 50th wedding anniversary by renewing their vows. "I never got that big church wedding, with that beautiful dress with the veil," she confessed. "But this time I did. We just had a lovely ceremony. It was very sweet."

Dean died in 2025, aged 82. There is something comforting in imagining them together again.

– Daily Mirror

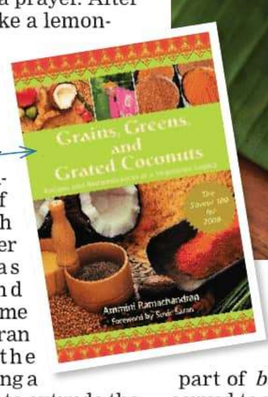
Murukkus Show That Extruded Foods Can be Healthy and Delicious

FOOD FABLES

VIKRAM DOCTOR

When Ammini Ramachandran's mother wanted *murukkus*, she called Janu Ammiyaar, a neighbour known for her expertise in making these crunchy spiral snacks. In her book *Grains, Greens, and Grated Coconuts*, Ramachandran describes Ammiyaar mixing rice and urad dal flours with cumin, sesame, salt and water in which a lump of asafoetida had been soaked and then kneading this dough till it was just the right silky texture.

She would then pinch a piece into a pyramid to represent Lord Ganesha, and say a prayer. After that, she would take a lemon-sized lump and start twisting it into a curly strand that was coiled into a spiral: "Watching her effortlessly turn out thin, multi-layered circles of curly spirals, with just her index finger and thumb, was fascinating and dissuading at the same time." Ramachandran recommended the easier option of using a hand-turned press to extrude the dough in strands that were coiled and kept ready for deep-frying.



PIC: GETTY IMAGES

Thousands of *murukku* presses must be in action now, preparing for Ganesh Chaturthi next month.

Murukku is an essential part of *bakshanam*, the snacks served to welcome guests, and no one is more welcome than Lord Ganesha. There are many varieties, ranging from the original hand-formed *kai murukku* to the variations in form made possible by different discs in the press, like *mul murukku*, covered with little prickles (*mul* in Tamil) for extra crunch or the smooth coils of *thenkuzhal*.

While the rice-urad flour combination is classic, many variations are possible with different grains and pulses. Butter or ghee in the dough adds a luxurious touch. Ribbon *pakoda* ditches the coils for short pasta-like lengths. Tamilians have taken the snack around the world, like South Africa, where *murkoos* are made with maize and given flavours like Italian herb or spring onion. Green *murukkus* made with spinach paste are popular in Tamil Nadu now, but I find the dark red versions made with beetroot too startling.

I have even had a non-veg *murukku* made with dried fish powder, prepared by a marine scientist at a fisheries fair.

Murukkus are so varied that it can be deeply annoying to hear North Indians lump them all as *chaklis*. They should also be given credit as precursors to the giant industry that has developed around extruded foods. Hand-turned pasta makers have been around since the 17th century, with one of the earliest references intriguingly coming from Thomas Jefferson, the USA's third president. In Judson M Harper's highly technical manual *Extrusion of Foods*, he writes that "General Mills Inc was the first to use an extruder in the manufacture of ready to eat (RTE) cereals in the late 1930s". The pet food industry was the first to take up extrusion in a big way, creating pellets of animal protein that were dried for easy storage and use.

In *Pandora's Lunchbox*, Melanie Warner's exposé of the impact of highly processed foods on the American diet, she notes how "extrusion machines could take multiple ingredients, mix them together rapidly and form cereal into a potentially endless array of fun-filled shapes". Extruded breakfast foods and snacks were big sellers, but came with a hidden cost. The high-speed machines couldn't handle fibres, so only the starchiest, least-nutritious parts of grains were used. The extrusion process created heat, which was seen as useful in killing bacteria, but it also damaged nutrients such as vitamins, which then had to be chemically added back.

Warner damns extruded foods for creating the highly-addictive-yet-nutritionally-compromised foods that have inflicted huge harm on childhood diets in particular, leading to an explosion of obesity and poor health: "Extrusion is undoubtedly the harshest and most nutritionally devastating way to process cereal." It is a pity that the US never took its cue from *murukkus*, whose pulse flours make them more nutritious, and whose many variations, with millets and other grains, could have offered a better model for excellent extruded foods.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES | BENGALURU | SUNDAY | 30 AUGUST 2026 | WWW.ECONOMICTIMES.COM

VITALS

Ligament Tear Ends Neeraj's Season, Out of Asian Games

New Delhi: India's two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra on Saturday announced that he has suffered ligament tear in his ankle during training, ruling him out of the upcoming Asian Games. Chopra said in a social media post that he sustained the injury shortly after producing a season-best throw in Lausanne. "Unfortunately, shortly after, I sustained a ligament tear in my ankle during training. After discussions with my doctor and team, we've decided that I will sit out the rest of this season. It's disappointing, especially because I felt close to finding my rhythm. But as they say, setbacks are a part of the journey," Chopra said. Chopra's withdrawal from the season also means he will miss the Diamond League Final, for which he had qualified. **PTI**

Harmanpreet Says Defense Needs Improvement

Wavre: India's disappointing eighth-place finish at the FIH World Cup has exposed their defensive shortcomings, with captain Harmanpreet Singh admitting that the team needs to improve significantly in that area. India finished eighth after losing 3-4 to co-hosts Belgium in a penalty shootout in the final classification match on Friday. Former champions Belgium held a 3-2 lead until the final minute, but 26 seconds before the hooter, Harmanpreet converted a penalty corner to force the match into a shootout. The Indian skipper scored eight goals in the tournament. "There are no individual goals. If we win, we win as a team, and if we lose, it is also collective responsibility. We've learnt good lessons in defence throughout the tournament. If we don't defend well as a team, big teams will trouble you. We need to be stronger defensively. This is one area where we lagged behind," he said. **PTI**

Miandad Appeals for Release of Imran Khan

New Delhi: Pakistan batting great Javed Miandad broke down while speaking about the imprisonment of his former teammate and 1992 World Cup-winning captain Imran Khan, making an emotional appeal for his release. The 73-year-old Imran has been lodged at Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi since 2023 after being convicted in corruption cases. "He is an honest man. He is not someone who engages in corrupt practices, otherwise he would have done a lot of things," Miandad said in an interview with the Narrative YouTube channel. "What will happen if you let him out? Will he eat or damage someone? He is also someone's son. I always think about what he must be doing," he added, visibly emotional while speaking about his former teammate. **PTI**

Norris Locks in Long-term F1 Future at McLaren

London: Defending world champion Lando Norris has extended his contract with McLaren until at least the end of 2030, the F1 team said Saturday. McLaren said the new deal features "a multi-year option to commit beyond that date." Financial terms were not announced. The Press Association news agency said the British driver's new contract could be worth up to $35 million a year. The 26-year-old Norris secured McLaren's first drivers' title last year since Lewis Hamilton won his first championship in 2008. "McLaren is my home," Norris said. "When I started this journey nine years ago, I was clear about the goals I wanted to achieve: to get McLaren back to the front and to win championships. We've achieved that goal, but we want more; we want to keep on winning, and we know as a team that we're capable of achieving it." **AP**

THE STARS ALIGN IN NEW YORK

With champions returning, favourites faltering and challengers circling, the **US Open** arrives at Flushing Meadows with plenty of questions and few certainties

Carlitos Is Back

Alcaraz returns to court with questions to answer as Djokovic, Zverev and a host of challengers eye the crown

Gaurav Kalra — CHIP N CHARGE

COCO GAUFF

CARLOS ALCARAZ

Since returning from an injury-induced five-month hiatus, Carlos Alcaraz has incited a collective swooning over his hair. A bold typeface headline in GQ proclaims, "This is the coolest Carlos Alcaraz has ever looked", waxing lyrical about how he's now "armed with flowing locks." Alcaraz hasn't hit yet the singles court, but his pairing with the legendary Serena Williams in the mixed doubles event preceding the US Open captivated the sporting world. They won a match and lost the next, but the results mattered little.

Because the man fans fondly called "Carlitos", just 23 years old and already owner of seven major titles title, is back playing the sport that has desperately felt his absence. While the admirable efficiency of Jannik Sinner, the relentless valour of Novak Djokovic and the ferocious breakthrough of Alexander Zverev have provided compelling storylines, tennis has been devoid of the joie de vivre that only the precocious Spaniard brings. Alcaraz, undoubtedly, has missed tennis all these months, but let there be no doubt – tennis has missed him as much, if not more.

Now, Alcaraz returns to the US Open, where he won his first slam in 2022 at age 19, and sizzled through the field for his second title last year, as the second seed behind Zverev. With his fiercest modern day rival Sinner missing through injury, the spotlight will shine even brighter on Alcaraz.

In the mixed doubles hit out, Alcaraz didn't quite produce the spark that underlined his pre-injury dominance, with some observers describing him as "rusty". Perhaps, he doesn't quite trust his wrist entirely yet and perhaps, all he needs is those proverbial "miles in the legs" over the first few rounds to reignite the warrior within.

"A lot of the time he pulls shots out of nowhere," former US Open champion Andy Roddick said on his podcast. "For him to play this, I have to think the risk of further injury is next to nothing. It seems like he's happy to accept that 'hey, listen, maybe my legs will be tired. Maybe I haven't played any match reps. I might lose first or second round, but I'm going to go'. This is such a win for tennis."

While Alcaraz will look to find his groove, others will sense their opportunity in his frailty, and Sinner's absence.

Zverev, who has leapfrogged Alcaraz to second in the rankings, is primed to extend the purple patch that saw him clinch a first ever major at the French Open and reach the Wimbledon final. Results in hard court tune-ups have been underwhelming for the German, and he hasn't been past the fourth round in his last five outings in New York after making the final in 2020, but Zverev has all the tools to make another deep run.

However, the conversation that will attract most chatter after Alcaraz, will be Novak Djokovic's resumption of the pursuit for a 25th major title. The four-time winner, seeded fourth, has played a mere 20 matches all year and was packed off in his only tune-up event at Cincinnati by unheralded Argentine Thiago Tirante. Yet, come slam time, Djokovic transforms into a credible threat, hell bent on extracting every ounce of tennis from his 39-year-old self.

"I have very high regard for Novak, I've seen what he can do, not just once, not just here, but every place — at the highest level," gushed his one-time great rival, Roger Federer. "As long as he's in the draw, there's a chance and I think that's one of the reasons he's still playing because he must believe he can do it, that's my opinion."

There are others of course knocking eagerly on the door for slam success, with the likes of Felix Auger Aliassime, Ben Shelton, Taylor Fritz, Flavio Cobolli and Frances Tiafoe in the mix. Who walks away with the biggest bite from the Big Apple this year will unfold over two weeks of high-octane action.

ALL TO PLAY FOR

Major question marks in women's field leave door open for Gauff, Swiatek

Amy Tennery

New York: Major question marks hang over the top two seeds in the women's field when the US Open main draw begins on Sunday, leaving the door open for past winners Coco Gauff and Iga Swiatek to bring home another trophy from Flushing Meadows.

Top seed Aryna Sabalenka's dismal back half of the season has clouded her pursuit of a rare third successive US Open title, while No. 2 Elena Rybakina's exit from Cincinnati with a leg injury has cast her campaign into doubt.

It has been a different story entirely for 2023 champion Gauff, who got her once-maligned serve working for her en route to the semis in Toronto and to her first title of the year with a confidence-inspiring performance in Cincinnati.

She will benefit, too, from the rowdy New York crowd, as a perennial American fan favourite.

"Coco Gauff played exceptional tennis in Cincinnati. She played well in Canada, as well. To me she's the one that's playing the best tennis," said ESPN commentator and former world number four Mary Joe Fernandez.

Fourth-ranked Gauff and third-ranked Jessica Pegula will be playing for national pride with US women failing to make the final at the first three majors this year.

$108 million (approximately ₹1,030 crore) the US Open 2026 prize pool is the largest in Grand Slam history. The singles champions are set to earn $5.5 million each

A 'BUMPY' JOURNEY FOR SWIATEK

Poland's six-times major winner Swiatek arrives in New York with fresh fight in her, shaking off bitter criticism back home to win her first title of the season in Toronto earlier this month.

Swiatek has not made it past the quarterfinals at any of the year's majors and had to fight her way back to top form in time for the North American hard court swing.

"The journey has been bumpy this season," the eighth-ranked Swiatek told reporters after she swatted aside Rybakina to lift the trophy in Canada. "Sometimes I was impatient throughout the season. I was, like, seeking (a win) while maybe my game was not ready."

But while Swiatek's form is peaking at the best time, Sabalenka's has dipped at the worst, as she has failed to reach a final since completing the Sunshine Double this year. "She struggled a bit winning the big points. She's lost a couple big leads in some events," said Fernandez. "She's vulnerable."

If she wins, she would become only the third woman in the Open Era to "three-peat" at Flushing Meadows - and the first since Serena Williams claimed a trio of titles between 2012 and 2014 - as she closes in on 100 straight weeks atop the rankings.

Other contenders include Russian teen Mirra Andreeva, who claimed her maiden major title at Roland Garros this year, and Czech Linda Noskova, who carved out her own slice of the spotlight with a breakthrough Wimbledon title last month.

And the Philippines' Alexandra Eala made believers out of many when she beat four-time major winner Naomi Osaka and Pegula to win the WTA 500 title in DC this month. **Reuters**

The first month was kind of difficult for me because I couldn't do anything with my right arm. But finally, here we are. My goal was try to be healthy as soon as possible and try not to miss more competitions. So I would say that intrusive thoughts were the most difficult things to deal with in this process

CARLOS ALCARAZ on his time out due to injury

US OPEN
146th Edition
VENUE Billie Jean King National Tennis Center
LOCATION Queens, New York
COURT TYPE Hard

Total Participants (singles)
256
128 men, 128 women

How entries are accepted
DIRECT ACCEPTANCE
104 (ranking based)
QUALIFIERS
16 (qualifying event)
WILD CARDS
8 (granted by organisers)

Last 5 Champions (singles)

WOMEN	
2025	Aryna Sabalenka
2024	Aryna Sabalenka
2023	Coco Gauff
2022	Iga Swiatek
2021	Emma Raducanu
MEN	
2025	Carlos Alcaraz
2024	Jannik Sinner
2023	Novak Djokovic
2022	Carlo Alcaraz
2021	Daniil Medvedev

Time 8:30pm onwards
LIVE on Star Sports & JioHotstar

It's clear now that Shubman Gill has a mind of his own and has no difficulty in standing by his decisions

Beyond the Result

India's 1-0 series win over Sri Lanka offered plenty to ponder, from the limitations of two-Test series to Gill's growing authority as captain

Anand Vasu — BAT ON REGARDLESS

For one tiny second, let us pretend the World Test Championship does not exist. Or, if that's not possible, that we inhabit a world in which it is not the be-all and end-all of the cricketing universe.

To that end, the India-Sri Lanka series, which ended 1-0 in the visiting team's favour, but left the home team feeling right on top after they battled to a stunning draw at the Sinhalese Sports Club in Colombo. There were lessons aplenty, for both sides.

TWO IS TOO FEW

Gautam Gambhir, almost unprompted, said that two Tests were not ideal for a series. His reasoning, even with India leading, was that a team should always have option of winning a series even after losing the first Test.

Even setting his logic aside, Gambhir was absolutely right. Consider this series. India had seen enough of Kuldeep Yadav after one Test, in which he did not have the captain's confidence.

In the second, India brought in Saransh Jain, who made his debut at 33. Gill backed Saransh, giving him long spells in both innings and even handing him the new ball. By the end of it, though, it was clear that Saransh was not the answer to India's off-spin problems. Had there been a third Test, what might India have done? There are no other spinners on the radar and India would have been forced to play a combination that was not their first choice.

Similarly, what would Sri Lanka have done, having bowled Asitha Fernando and Lahiru Kumara into the ground? It's not as though they have many fast bowling options.

We won't know the answer to these questions, because two-Test series are just not good enough.

WILL CAPTAIN GILL STAND UP?

The question before this series began, with Shubman Gill approaching a year at the helm of the Test and ODI teams, was when he would make this team his own. For a while now, the whisper has been that this was Gambhir's team, with the head coach calling all the shots.

But it's clear now that Gill has a mind of his own and has no difficulty in standing by his decisions. More than once during the series, when things were meandering on the field, a message would come out from the dressing room, usually delivered by Sarfaraz Khan. Gill listened to the input but did his own thing. Occasionally, he waved Sarfaraz away even before he could fully convey what he had been sent out to say.

When it came to the declaration, Gill had several choices before him. He chose to balance runs and time as he thought fit, and that included Dhruv Jurel getting to his Test hundred. In hindsight, there may be some nitpicking on this count, but at least it was a call the captain made and could own.

WHY POTENTIAL IS NOT ENOUGH

India arrived in Sri Lanka vulnerable. They may not admit it but there was a real chance that they could have been in trouble. India's recent record against spin has been dodgy on tough pitches at home. Sri Lanka are masters at playing on turners in their backyard, especially in Galle where Prabhat Jayasuriya is king.

India should take note that their best chance, even at home, is to play on pitches that allow their batsmen to express themselves fully

For whatever reason, Sri Lanka chose not to go full-on when it comes to turning tracks. And this allowed India's batsmen, especially those who enjoy bounce, such as Devdutt Padikkal, to back themselves and come good.

India should take note that their best chance, even at home, is to play on pitches that allow their batsmen to express themselves fully.

Sri Lanka, on a similar note, are owning their identity as a developing team. Not one in transition, like India, but one that is growing into being the best version of itself. And Sonal Dinusha, making the most of every chance, with the lower order, showed that runs on the board and performance under pressure is the real pathway to growth.

Sri Lanka, under the astute eye of Gary Kirsten, will know that they now need to back players who lift their game at the highest level and are hungry to change the team's performances, not just players who make pretty little scores and hope for the best.

While both Tests in this series went the distance — itself a rarity in modern cricket anywhere in the world — the only reason it shone light so clearly on the way forward was the balance between bat and ball. Had it not been for rain in Colombo, this would have been sharpened, and then there would have been nowhere to hide.

India Seek a Reset

Consistency, form in spotlight as Women in Blue begin Asia Cup campaign against Thailand

Dubai: India will look to banish their ordinary run in the shortest format and address questions over their consistency and form when they take on Thailand in their Women's T20 Asia Cup Group A opener tonight.

India have been the most dominant team in the Women's T20 Asia Cup over the last decade, winning the title three times in five editions since the tournament switched to the T20 format in 2016-17. But their recent performances have raised more concerns than provided assurances.

India have lost nine of their 16 T20Is this year, with their most recent defeat — against Australia in the Women's T20 World Cup — sending them crashing out of the competition at the group stage.

With questions persisting over captain Harmanpreet Kaur's form and future in the shortest format, India enter a crucial phase, with two Asian-level competitions ahead in which they will be expected to go the distance.

Following the eight-team Women's T20 Asia Cup, where India are in Group A alongside Thailand, Hong Kong and Pakistan, they will travel to Japan for next month's Asian Games, again with expectations of adding to their medal haul.

After a largely disappointing campaign at the Women's T20 World Cup, Harmanpreet produced when it mattered most in the crucial clash against Australia. But her inconsistency with the bat remained one of the talking points of a campaign in which India struggled against the higher-ranked teams.

With dependable batter Jemimah Rodrigues sidelined for the Asia Cup and Asian Games, India have added Pratika Rawal to their studded squad, but the choice hardly settles the requirement for a middle-order enforcer.

At the top, India will continue to have the formidable opening pair of Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma, but the biggest challenge for batters at No. 3 and beyond would be to sustain momentum and provide further impetus to the scoreboard.

Poor fielding was again a major concern the last time India played in the format, as a string of dropped chances near the ropes led to their downfall, and the team management would be desperate to have their bases covered this time around.

India will rely on their seasoned all-rounder Deepti Sharma to lead the spin attack once again, with Shree Charani, the highest wicket-taker of the T20 World Cup, Radha Yadav and Prema Rawat sharing the workload.

India's seam bowling arsenal looks potent too, with the experienced Renuka Singh Thakur having the likes of Kranti Gaud, Arundhati Reddy and Nandani Sharma to share the responsibilities. **PTI**

WOMEN'S T20 ASIA CUP
INDIA vs THAILAND
DUBAI INTERNATIONAL CRICKET STADIUM

FORM
LWLWW WWLWW

LAST 3 MATCHES
IND won by 74 runs
IND won by 9 wkts
IND won by 66 runs

8pm | Sony Ten, SonyLIV

SMRITI MANDHANA

We don't pay too much attention to the form. We know what scope of improvement this team has. This is a young side. If you look at it, we are trying to play some good aggressive cricket. And from here on, we will try and set the tone for the next six months

AMOL MUZUMDAR India's head coach

LIVERPOOL 2-2 NOTTINGHAM FOREST

Munoz Rocket Salvages Point on Iraola's Anfield Debut

Lori Ewing

Liverpool: Liverpool's Victor Munoz struck a late equaliser to salvage a 2-2 draw against Nottingham Forest on Saturday, but Andoni Iraola's side were left still searching for their first Premier League win of the season after his first home league game in charge.

Forest had looked set to leave Anfield with all three points, in what would have been a first league victory in charge for Oliver Glasner, when Morgan Gibbs-White converted a 70th-minute penalty, awarded after Liverpool goalkeeper Alisson fouled Neco Williams in the area, for a 2-1 lead.

But newcomer Munoz, in his first start for Liverpool, equalised in the 82nd minute, when he spun and blasted a shot from the edge of the box that went in off the crossbar.

FOREST LED AT HALF-TIME

Forest had opened the scoring through Dan Ndoye in the 24th minute, the Swiss forward finishing off a rapid counterattack that began with goalkeeper, Matz Sels, launching a long ball upfield before Gibbs-White slipped him through to slot coolly into the bottom corner.

Liverpool had a first-half effort from Florian Wirtz chalked off after a VAR review determined Jeremie Frimpong was offside in the build-up, before finally levelling in the 60th minute when Alexander Isak scored.

Cody Gakpo twisted away from his marker on the right and whipped a low ball across the face of goal, with Isak tapping into an empty net after two Forest defenders failed to make contact.

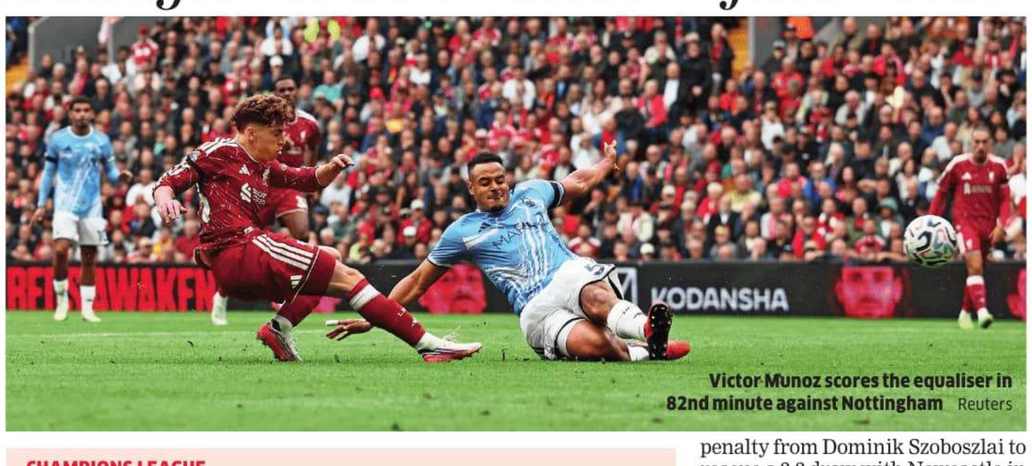
"It's been good, there is always time to get used to a new style," Isak said. "We are really working hard to try to play the game (Iraola) wants us to play, when we start doing that better I have no doubt the results will come as well."

TWO DRAWS SO FAR FOR LIVERPOOL

Liverpool had needed a stoppage-time penalty from Dominik Szoboszlai to rescue a 2-2 draw with Newcastle in their league opener six days earlier.

Saturday's result left Liverpool with two draws from two league matches under Iraola, who was appointed this summer after the club followed up its 2025 Premier League title triumph with a disappointing fifth-place finish under Arne Slot last season, despite their £446 million spending spree a year ago.

Iraola has reinforcements on the way as the club finalised an agreement to sign French forward Bradley Barcola from European champions Paris St Germain earlier on Saturday, according to British media reports, with the 23-year-old set to become the latest high-profile addition to Iraola's squad. **Reuters**



Victor Munoz scores the equaliser in 82nd minute against Nottingham Reuters

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

REAL MADRID HOST INTER TO OPEN MAIN PHASE

Nyon: Record 15-time European champions Real Madrid will start the league phase of the Champions League on Sept. 8 when they host Inter Milan. Match dates for each of the 36 teams' eight-game schedules were published Saturday by UEFA, two days after the draw in Monaco. One day later, defending champion Paris Saint-Germain will host Slovan Bratislava – coached by Yaya Touré, the first African leading a team at the league phase – and Liverpool will host Atletico Madrid, a repeat of their opening game last season. That was a 3-2 win for Liverpool at Anfield. Debut-making Sabah of Azerbaijan will start at Manchester United on Sept. 10, the same day Como hosts Leipzig and Bayern Munich welcomes Bodø/Glimt. Manchester City hosting PSG on Oct. 14 is a highlight of the second round of games played more than one month later, after the new and extended four-game slate for national teams. PSG will then face Barcelona at Parc des Princes on Oct. 20, one day before Bayern Munich hosts Arsenal. Barcelona's next trip will then be a long way east to play Sabah in Baku on Nov. 25, before the Spanish champions host Man City on Dec. 8. Arsenal will host Real Madrid on Dec. 9 for the first of coach Jose Mourinho's scheduled two visits to London. **AP**

WATCHOUT! Tonight
PREMIER LEAGUE **Chelsea v Brighton** 6:30pm; **Man United v Ipswich** 9pm (Star Sports)
LA LIGA **Real Madrid v Málaga** 8:30pm (Fancode)